STUDY BOOKLET · 10 NOVEMBER 2026 · 30 CHESHVAN 5787

Wells, Psalms and the New Knesset

A study booklet for 30 Cheshvan 5787: Tehillim 145–150, Parashas Toldos, Kuntres Acharon, Bechoros 53 and Rosh Chodesh Kislev

---

Thirteen chapters on the fifty topics of the day, with the sources in Hebrew and English, the commentators, and questions for the table

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, Torah scholar, researcher and writer

Wells, Psalms and the New Knesset

A study booklet for 30 Cheshvan 5787: Tehillim 145–150, Parashas Toldos, Kuntres Acharon, Bechoros 53 and Rosh Chodesh Kislev

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren, Torah scholar, researcher and writer

10 November 2026 · 30 Cheshvan 5787 · Rosh Chodesh Kislev · Jerusalem
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

About this booklet

On Tuesday 10 November 2026, the thirtieth of Cheshvan 5787, several cycles of Jewish learning met on one day. The monthly cycle of Tehillim reached its last six psalms, 145 to 150. The weekly Chumash portion reached the third aliyah of Toldos, Yitzchak and the wells. The daily Tanya portion was the middle of the third essay of Kuntres Acharon. The Daf Yomi was Bechoros 53. And it was the first day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev. On the same afternoon, the 26th Knesset was sworn in, while talks over the war with Iran and the Strait of Hormuz went on.

A sheet of fifty study topics was drawn up for the day. Many of the topics repeat or overlap, so this booklet gathers them into thirteen chapters. Each chapter opens with the list of sheet topics it covers, works through the primary texts with the classical commentators, sets them beside the events of the day where the sheet asks for it, and ends with questions for the table. Six chapters also print the full Hebrew and English text of the passage they study. The appendix lists all fifty topics by number with the chapter where each is treated.

A note on the texts

Every Hebrew and Aramaic quotation was cut directly from the text opened on Sefaria or Chabad.org on 10 November 2026 and checked against it. Vowels and cantillation marks are removed. The Divine Name is never printed: it appears as ה' and, where the text has a shorter name, as [ה']; other names appear in their customary substitute forms, such as אלקים. In English, divine names are written Hashem, G-d and L-rd.

The English renderings of the commentators, the Gemara and the Tanya are working translations prepared for this booklet, kept close to the Hebrew. Where a published translation was consulted, the bibliography names it. The full texts of Tehillim and Bereishis use the 1985 translation of the Jewish Publication Society. Readers who teach from this booklet should check any quotation against a printed edition.

How the facts were checked

Seat and turnout figures come only from the Central Elections Committee's official final results, published on 4 November 2026. No opinion polls are cited anywhere in this booklet. The mandate given to Gadi Eisenkot, the swearing-in of the Knesset, and the attendance of President Isaac Herzog and Speaker Amir Ohana were checked against dated news reports, listed in the bibliography. Every date is given in full.

This booklet tries to keep the laws of proper speech. It reports what leaders and governments said and did, as published, and does not guess at anyone's motives.

What could not be confirmed

Some items on the sheet could not be confirmed from the sources opened for this booklet. They are listed here, and each is handled the same way in the chapter where it comes up.

- **Turnout.** The sheet gives turnout as 77.9 per cent. That matches an earlier published count of 30 October 2026. The official final figure of 4 November 2026 is 77.98 per cent (5,717,397 votes of 7,331,981 eligible), and that is the figure used here. All eleven seat figures on the sheet match the final results.
- **Shipping through the Strait at "about 8 per cent" of normal.** Not confirmed. UKMTO counted 325 transits from 29 October to 4 November 2026, about 65 per cent below pre-conflict levels; the Joint Maritime Information Center reported single-digit to low double-digit daily transits; Straits.live put traffic below a tenth of the pre-crisis count. The trackers disagree, and the 8 per cent figure is not used (chapters 2 and 4).
- **"Day 256" of the closure.** Approximate. Counting 28 February 2026 as the first day, 10 November is the 256th day; Straits.live showed "Day 254" on 10 November (chapter 2).
- **A regional preference for the status quo.** Reported, but only as President Trump's description of other governments' views, in a Reuters report of 10 November 2026. The UAE's Anwar Gargash said on 1 November that restoring the Strait to its prewar state was non-negotiable. It is treated as a contested claim, not a fact (chapters 9 and 10).
- **Conditions of the crews.** The International Maritime Organization figure of 25 seafarers dead since 28 February is reported by The National and Al Jazeera; Deutsche Welle cites the International Transport Workers' Federation for more than 40. The National reported about 400 ships and 6,000 seafarers stuck as of late October. The figures do not agree, and the chapters say so (chapters 2 and 4).
- **Bechoros 53.** The sheet describes the page as one on "valuation and firstborn obligations." The page is mainly about the tithe of animals; valuations and firstborns appear as comparisons. Chapter 12 follows the page as it reads.

Contents

About this booklet **2**

1. A Praise of David: The Missing Nun and the Arithmetic of 120 ..... **6**

The text in full: Tehillim 145 ..... *12*

2. Hashem Supports All Who Fall: Crews, Provision and the Eyes of All **16**

3. Do Not Trust in Princes: The Mandate and Its Days **23**

The text in full: Tehillim 146 ..... *28*

4. He Keeps Faith Forever: The Sea, the Bound and the Reign **30**

5. Builder of Jerusalem: Stars, Horses and the Humble **35**

The text in full: Tehillim 147 ..... *40*

6. Kings of the Earth: Psalm 148 and the Swearing-In **44**

The text in full: Tehillim 148 ..... *48*

7. A New Song: The Two-Edged Sword of Psalm 149 ..... **52**

The text in full: Tehillim 149 ..... *56*

8. Let Every Soul Praise: Psalm 150 and Tehillim with a Minyan **58**

The text in full: Tehillim 150 ..... *62*

9. The Stopped Wells: Growth, Envy and the Stated Reason **65**

The text in full: Bereishis 26:12–16 ..... *70*

10. Esek, Sitnah, Rechovos: Living Water and the Wide Spaces **72**

The text in full: Bereishis 26:17–22 ..... *78*

11. Words That Rise: Kuntres Acharon on Speech and Intention **80**

12. Under the Rod: Bechoros 53 and Honest Counting **85**

13. Blessing the New Month: Rosh Chodesh Kislev and Unfinished Things **90**

Appendix: the fifty topics and their chapters **94**

Bibliography **96**

CHAPTER 1

A Praise of David: The Missing Nun and the Arithmetic of 120

Tehillim 145:1–13 with Berachos 4b, Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David, set beside the final count of the 26th Knesset

Topics from the sheet: 1. Alphabetic structure of Psalm 145 vs incomplete Knesset arithmetic; 16. Psalm 145:13 temporary character of any single administration; 27. Alphabetic completeness vs incomplete mandate period

The day's portion

On Tuesday 10 November 2026, 30 Cheshvan 5787, the monthly cycle of Tehillim reaches its last six psalms, 145 to 150. Anyone who keeps the cycle has been reading them for a lifetime, because Tehillim 145 is Ashrei, said three times a day, and the five that follow are the heart of Pesukei deZimra every morning. On this one day of the month they are read as the end of the whole book.

The same afternoon, the 26th Knesset was sworn in at the Knesset in Jerusalem. That is a coincidence of the calendar and nothing more. Still, a person who said Ashrei at Shacharis and then watched the ceremony could hardly miss the contrast. The psalm is built on the full alphabet, from aleph to tav, with one letter left out on purpose. The parliament came together in the arithmetic of 120 seats, with no government yet formed. This chapter sets the two side by side. It does not claim that the psalm predicts anything about Israeli politics. It asks what the psalm teaches a person to notice.

An alphabet with a gap

> תהלה לדוד ארוממך אלוקי המלך ואברכה שמך לעולם ועד
>
> *A praise of David. I will exalt You, my G-d the King, and bless Your name for ever and ever.*
> Tehillim 145:1

Tehillim 145 is the only psalm in the book headed *Tehillah*: *Tehillah leDavid*, "a praise of David." Metzudas David explains why the heading fits.

לפי שבהמזמור הזה אין בה שום שאלה ובקשה כ״א שבחי המקום ולזה אמר תהלה לדוד כי אין בה כ״א תהלה ושבח

“A praise of David”: because in this psalm there is no question or request at all, only the praises of the Omnipresent; therefore he said “a praise of David,” for there is nothing in it but praise and glory.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:1

Nothing is requested. The psalm only praises. Then it runs through the letters in order, one verse to a letter. The reader who follows the letters will find that between *mem* (verse 13) and *samech* (verse 14) there is no verse that begins with *nun*.

מלכותך מלכות כל־עלמים וממשלתך בכל־דור ודר

Your kingship is a kingship of all worlds, and Your dominion is in every generation and generation.

Tehillim 145:13

סומך ה׳ לכל־הנפלים וזוקף לכל־הכפופים

Hashem supports all who fall, and straightens all who are bent down.

Tehillim 145:14

The Gemara in Berachos asks why this psalm, of all the alphabetical psalms, earned its place three times a day.

כל האומר ״תהלה לדוד״ בכל יום שלש פעמים — מובטח לו שהוא בן העולם הבא

Rabbi Elazar said in the name of Rabbi Avina: Whoever says “A praise of David” three times every day is assured that he belongs to the World to Come.

Berachos 4b

אילימא משום דאתיא באלף בית, נימא ״אשרי תמימי דרך״ דאתיא בתמניא אפין. אלא משום דאית ביה ״פותח את ידך״, נימא ״הלל הגדול״ דכתיב ביה ״נתן לחם לכל בשר״. אלא משום דאית ביה תרתי

If you say it is because it runs in alphabetical order, let him say “Happy are those whose way is perfect” (Tehillim 119), which runs in eightfold order. Rather, because it contains “You open Your hand”? Let him say the Great Hallel, in which is written “He gives bread to all flesh.” Rather, because it contains both.

Berachos 4b

The answer is careful. The alphabet alone is not enough, because Tehillim 119 runs through the alphabet eight times. Provision alone is not enough, because the Great Hallel also speaks of bread for all flesh. Ashrei has both: completeness of form and the open hand. Then Rabbi Yochanan turns to the missing letter.

אמר רבי יוחנן: מפני מה לא נאמר נון ב"אשרי" — מפני שיש בה מפלתן של שונאי ישראל, דכתיב: "נפלה לא תוסיף קום בתולת ישראל". במערבא מתרצי לה הכי: "נפלה ולא תוסיף לנפול עוד, קום בתולת ישראל". אמר רב נחמן בר יצחק: אפילו הכי, חזר דוד וסמכן ברוח הקדש, שנאמר "סומך ה' לכל הנפלים"

Rabbi Yochanan said: Why is there no nun in Ashrei? Because it contains the fall of the enemies of Israel [a euphemism for Israel itself], as it is written, "She has fallen and will rise no more, the maiden of Israel" (Amos 5:2). In the West [the Land of Israel] they read it this way: "She has fallen and will fall no more; rise, maiden of Israel." Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak said: Even so, David went back and supported them with the holy spirit, as it says, "Hashem supports all who fall."

Berachos 4b

נפלה לא־תוסיף קום בתולת ישראל נטשה על־אדמתה אין מקימה

She has fallen and will rise no more, the maiden of Israel; she is cast down on her land, there is none to raise her up.

Amos 5:2

Rashi on the verse brings the same teaching in brief.

נו"ן חסרה מאלפ"א בית"א, לפי שראה דוד בה מפלה קשה: "נפלה ולא תוסיף קום בתולת ישראל" (עמוס ה:ב), וחזר וסמכה ברוח הקדש: סומך ה' לכל הנופלים

The nun is missing from the alphabet because David saw in it a grievous fall: "She has fallen and will rise no more, the maiden of Israel" (Amos 5:2). And he went back and supported her by the holy spirit: "Hashem supports all who fall" (Berachos 4b).

Rashi on Tehillim 145:14

So the gap is not an accident of transmission. It is a decision. David saw the verse of Amos that would one day begin with *nun*, a verse of falling, and he would not give the fall its own line. He went on to *samech*, *somech*, and wrote "Hashem supports all who fall." The fall is acknowledged by its absence. The support is written out in full.

What the missing letter teaches

There are three lessons here, and each one matters for the day.

The first is that completeness in praise is not the same as completeness in the world. The alphabet of Ashrei has twenty-one letters. Our generation counts and recounts its own numbers, and the numbers rarely come out whole.

The second is that a gap can be left honestly. David did not pretend that the *nun* belonged to praise. He left the space and let the reader feel it. The Gemara reports that

in the Land of Israel they read Amos with a different break: “She has fallen and will fall no more; rise, maiden of Israel.” Both readings keep the fall in view. Neither denies it.

The third is that the next line belongs to Hashem. The psalm moves from the absent *nun* straight to the One who supports. The order is the teaching. When people are short, the verse that follows the shortfall is His.

The arithmetic of 120

The Central Elections Committee published its official final results for the election of 27 October 2026 on Wednesday 4 November 2026. Eleven lists passed the threshold and divided the 120 seats as follows:

- Likud, 27
- Yashar!, 21
- Together (B’Yachad), 12
- The Joint List, 11
- The Democrats, 8
- Ra’am, 8
- Yisrael Beytenu, 7
- Otzma Yehudit, 7
- United Torah Judaism, 7
- Shas, 6
- Religious Zionism with Zehut, 6

The committee gave the final turnout as 77.98 percent. Grouped the way the press has grouped them since election night, the bloc led by Benjamin Netanyahu holds 53 seats, the four-party bloc led by Gadi Eisenkot holds 48, and the two Arab-led lists hold 19. No group reaches 61.

These are the only numbers in this booklet about seats and turnout, and they are the committee’s own. They describe how the people voted. They do not tell anyone what to think of the result, and nothing in these pages argues for any party.

A mandate measured in days

On the evening of Saturday 7 November 2026, President Isaac Herzog announced that he would task Gadi Eisenkot with forming the next government. According to the Times of Israel, factions totalling 67 members of the Knesset had recommended Eisenkot and 46 had recommended Benjamin Netanyahu, while United Torah Judaism recommended no one. The formal ceremony was set for Sunday 8 November at the President’s

Residence. The law gives the candidate 28 days, and the President may extend that by up to 14.

So the first mandate of the 26th Knesset is counted in days, and the count began before the Knesset was even sworn in. That is the nature of human political time. It is bounded. It starts on a stated day and ends on a stated day, with a possible extension that is itself bounded. When the period ends, either a government stands before the Knesset or the process moves on.

The psalm speaks of a different kind of time.

> אינה מלכות בן אדם שיש לה הפסק או בחייו או במותו אבל מלכות [ה'] יתב' אין לה הפסק כי מלכותו מלכות כל העולמים כל הזמנים
>
> *[Your kingship] is not the kingship of a human being, which has an interruption, either in his life or at his death. But the kingship of G-d, may He be blessed, has no interruption, for His kingship is the kingship of all worlds, all times.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 145:13

> מלכותך - כל מלכות תפסק ומלכות השם עומדת לנצח
>
> *"Your kingship": every kingship comes to an end, and the kingship of Hashem stands forever.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:13

Radak says human kingship "has an interruption, either in his life or at his death." Ibn Ezra says it in five words: every kingship comes to an end. The verse of *mem* does not set itself against human government. It sets it in proportion. A mandate of 28 days, a Knesset elected for a term, a coalition when one forms: all of them sit inside a kingship of all worlds that has no interruption at all.

Generation to generation

The psalm's fourth verse explains how praise survives the shortness of any one lifetime.

> דור לדור ישבח מעשיך וגבורתיך יגידו
>
> *Generation to generation will praise Your works, and tell of Your mighty acts.*
>
> Tehillim 145:4

> כי דור הולך ודור בא יספר זה הדור שהולך טרם לכתו לדור אחר המעשים הנוראים שראו בימיהם והגבורות שראו בחייהם
>
> *For a generation goes and a generation comes. This generation that is going tells, before it goes, to another generation the awesome deeds it saw in its days and the mighty acts it saw in its lifetime.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 145:4

Radak's point is practical. No generation sees everything. Each one tells the next what it saw, before it goes. That is how a people keeps faith with events that no single person lived through.

The swearing-in had a small instance of this. The Jerusalem Post reported that Avi Harush, whose son Sgt. Reef Harush fell in combat in Gaza in April 2024, would recite Psalm 122 in the plenum. A father who lost a son read a psalm of Jerusalem to a new Knesset. Whatever any of us thinks about the politics of the day, that is one generation telling the next.

Greatness without searching out

> גדול ה' ומהלל מאד ולגדלתו אין חקר

Great is Hashem and highly praised; His greatness has no searching out.
Tehillim 145:3

The third verse sets the scale. His greatness has "no searching out." No count reaches it. That line stands at the head of a psalm that will, a few verses later, speak of His kingship in every generation.

> כבוד מלכותך יאמרו וגבורתך ידברו להודיע לבני האדם גבורתיו וכבוד הדר מלכותו

They will speak of the glory of Your kingship and talk of Your might, to make known to human beings His mighty acts, and the glorious splendour of His kingship.
Tehillim 145:11–12

The verses that follow give praise a job. The devout "speak of the glory of Your kingship" in order "to make known to human beings His mighty acts." Praise goes upward, and it is also told outward, so that others will know.

Praise that does not wait for the numbers

> בכל־יום אברכך ואהללה שמך לעולם ועד

Every day I will bless You, and praise Your name for ever and ever.
Tehillim 145:2

David begins with "I will exalt You, my G-d the King" and then, immediately, "every day." The praise is daily. It does not wait for a good result or a clear majority. The Gemara's teaching in Berachos puts Ashrei on the lips of every Jew three times a day, on good days and hard days alike.

There is something steadying in that. On the morning of a swearing-in, with no government formed and the mandate clock running, a person says the same twenty-one verses he said yesterday. The psalm does not change with the news. It asks the news to take its place inside a longer sentence.

What this chapter does not claim

It would be easy to draw a neat line from the missing *nun* to the missing government, as if the psalm were a commentary on this Knesset. That would be a misuse of the text. Chazal read the missing letter as a fall that David chose not to write. They did not read it as a political forecast, and neither should we.

What we may take is a habit of attention. When the numbers are incomplete, the psalm teaches us to say so plainly, to leave the gap visible, and to put the next line where it belongs. That is a discipline for writers and readers of the news as much as for anyone in the Knesset.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 145

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 תהלה לדוד ארוממך אלוקי המלך ואברכה שמך לעולם ועד

A song of praise. Of David.
I will extol You, my G-d and king,
and bless Your name forever and ever.

2 בכל־יום אברכך ואהללה שמך לעולם ועד

Every day will I bless You
and praise Your name forever and ever.

3 גדול ה' ומהלל מאד ולגדלתו אין חקר

Great is the L-RD and much acclaimed;
His greatness cannot be fathomed.

4 דור לדור ישבח מעשיך וגבורתיך יגידו

One generation shall laud Your works to another
and declare Your mighty acts.

5 הדר כבוד הודך ודברי נפלאתיך אשיחה

The glorious majesty of Your splendor
and Your wondrous acts will I recite.

6 ועזוז נוראתיך יאמרו וגדלתך אספרנה

Men shall talk of the might of Your awesome deeds,
and I will recount Your greatness.

7 זכר רב־טובך יביעו וצדקתך ירננו

They shall celebrate Your abundant goodness,
and sing joyously of Your beneficence.

8 חנון ורחום ה' ארך אפים וגדל־חסד

The L-RD is gracious and compassionate,
slow to anger and abounding in kindness.

9 טוב־ה' לכל ורחמיו על־כל־מעשיו

The L-RD is good to all,
and His mercy is upon all His works.

10 יודוך ה' כל־מעשיך וחסידיך יברכוכה

All Your works shall praise You, O L-RD,
and Your faithful ones shall bless You.

11 כבוד מלכותך יאמרו וגבורתך ידברו

They shall talk of the majesty of Your kingship,
and speak of Your might,

12 להודיע לבני האדם גבורתיו וכבוד הדר מלכותו

to make His mighty acts known among men
and the majestic glory of His kingship.

13 מלכותך מלכות כל־עלמים וממשלתך בכל־דור ודר

Your kingship is an eternal kingship;
Your dominion is for all generations.

14 סומך ה' לכל־הנפלים וזוקף לכל־הכפופים

The L-RD supports all who stumble,
and makes all who are bent stand straight.

15 עיני־כל אליך ישברו ואתה נותן־להם את־אכלם בעתו

The eyes of all look to You expectantly,
and You give them their food when it is due.

16 פותח את־ידך ומשביע לכל־חי רצון

You give it openhandedly,
feeding every creature to its heart's content.

17 צדיק ה' בכל־דרכיו וחסיד בכל־מעשיו

The L-RD is beneficent in all His ways
and faithful in all His works.

18 קרוב ה' לכל־קראיו לכל אשר יקראהו באמת

The L-RD is near to all who call Him,
to all who call Him with sincerity.

19 רצון־יראיו יעשה ואת־שועתם ישמע ויושיעם

He fulfills the wishes of those who fear Him;
He hears their cry and delivers them.

20 שומר ה' את־כל־אהביו ואת כל־הרשעים ישמיד

The L-RD watches over all who love Him,
but all the wicked He will destroy.

21 תהלת ה' ידבר־פי ויברך כל־בשר שם קדשו לעולם ועד

My mouth shall utter the praise of the L-RD,
and all creatures shall bless His holy name forever and ever.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Why does the Gemara need both the alphabet and the open hand to explain the place of Ashrei? What would be lost with only one of them?
2. David left the *nun* out rather than write a line of falling. When is it right to leave a gap visible, and when is that a way of avoiding the truth?
3. Radak contrasts human kingship, which "has an interruption," with Hashem's, which has none. How does that change the way you read the mandate period of 28 days?
4. What did your own family tell you that you did not see yourself? What will you tell the next generation about this autumn?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 145:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.145.1.1
- Tehillim 145:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.13

- Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.14
- Berachos 4b: https://www.sefaria.org/Berakhot.4b.15
- Amos 5:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Amos.5.2
- Rashi on Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.145.14.1
- Radak on Tehillim 145:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.13.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145.13.1
- Tehillim 145:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.4
- Radak on Tehillim 145:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.4.1
- Tehillim 145:3: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.3
- Tehillim 145:11–12: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.11-12
- Tehillim 145:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.2

CHAPTER 2

Hashem Supports All Who Fall: Crews, Provision and the Eyes of All

Tehillim 145:14–21 with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David, and the seafarers of the Gulf

Topics from the sheet: 2. Psalm 145:14 upholding the fallen applied to blocked wells and Hormuz; 26. Psalm 145:15–16 eyes of all look to You; ordinary household provision; 45. Psalm 145:17 Hashem is righteous in all His ways; 46. Upholding those who fall and condition of crews and vessels

From the gap to the hand

The last chapter ended at the verse of *samech*. This one stays there, because the sheet for 30 Cheshvan returns to it again and again: Hashem supports all who fall, the eyes of all look to Him, He is righteous in all His ways. These verses are the working centre of Ashrei. They are also the verses a person says most slowly when the news is heavy.

סומך ה' לכל־הנפלים וזוקף לכל־הכפופים

Hashem supports all who fall, and straightens all who are bent down.
Tehillim 145:14

Who are “the fallen” and “the bent”?

The commentators do not agree on one picture, and the range is worth having.

סומך וגו'. לבל יגיעו עדי ארץ:

“Supports…”: so that they do not reach the ground. “All who are bent”: those whose stature has already bent down to the ground.
Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:14

For Metzudas David, *somech* means catching a person before he reaches the ground. *Zokef* means lifting the one who is already bent all the way down. Two kinds of help, then: one that prevents the fall and one that reverses it.

סומך ה' לכל הנופלים. והכפופים והם העניים המרודים, ברחמיו עליהם סומך וזוקף אותם

“Hashem supports all who fall,” and the bent: these are the afflicted poor. In His mercy upon them He supports them and straightens them.
Radak on Tehillim 145:14

Radak reads the verse socially. The fallen and the bent are “the afflicted poor.” The support is mercy given to people with no strength of their own.

> סומך - וכל מלך זה ישפיל וזה ירים, זה יסמוך וזה יפול, כי לא יוכל לסמוך ולהרים הכל והשם לבדו הוא סומך הכל
>
> *“Supports”: every king lowers this one and raises that one, supports this one while that one falls, for he cannot support and raise everyone. Hashem alone supports all.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:14

Ibn Ezra reads it politically, and his comment is the sharpest in the group. Every king raises some and lowers others. That is not cruelty; it is the limit of any ruler. A government that supports one sector will, by its nature, leave another unsupported, because no human power can hold up everyone at once. “Hashem alone supports all.”

That line is a measure, not a slogan. It tells us what to expect from human arrangements and what not to expect. A ruler, a mediator or a navy may hold some people up. None of them holds up everyone. Any party that claims to have solved a crisis for all sides at once is claiming something the psalm reserves for Hashem.

Ships, crews and the people on board

The sheet links this verse to the Strait of Hormuz and the people at sea there. The facts, as far as they could be checked on 10 November 2026, are these.

The UK Maritime Trade Operations centre (UKMTO), in its weekly report for the week ending 6 November 2026, counted 325 transits of the strait between 29 October and 4 November, 170 outbound and 155 inbound. It put that at about 65 percent below pre-conflict levels. Gulf News, reporting the UKMTO figures on 10 November, added that the Joint Maritime Information Center saw only single-digit to low double-digit daily transits in independent tracking, and that counts differ because many vessels turn off their transponders. An independent tracker, Straits.live, said on 10 November that commercial transits were “running below a tenth of the pre-crisis vessel count.”

So the honest summary is that traffic is far below normal and that the trackers disagree on how far. A figure that circulated in earlier notes, about 8 percent of pre-crisis traffic visible on AIS, is not confirmed by any source opened for this booklet and is not used here. The count of days is also unsettled. Straits.live called 10 November “day 254 of closure.” Counting from 28 February 2026, the date UKMTO and the major outlets give for the start of the war, 10 November is the 256th day. Readers should treat both numbers as approximate.

About the crews, The National in Abu Dhabi reported on 9 November 2026 that 25 seafarers had died in attacks on tankers in and around the strait since 28 February, and

that around 400 ships carrying about 6,000 seafarers remained stuck at sea as of late October. Al Jazeera, on the same day, gave the same International Maritime Organization figure of at least 25 dead. A Deutsche Welle report quoted the International Transport Workers' Federation as saying that more than 40 sailors had been killed. The figures do not agree, and this booklet does not choose between them. The Mission to Seafarers told The National that about eight vessels had been abandoned by their owners off the UAE coast, with crews receiving support.

Behind every number is a person who cannot easily go home. The verse of *samech* does not tell us how to end a blockade. It tells us whom to look at first.

The eyes of all

> עיני־כל אליך ישברו ואתה נותן־להם את־אכלם בעתו פותח את־ידך ומשביע לכל־חי רצון
>
> *The eyes of all look to You with hope, and You give them their food in its time. You open Your hand and satisfy every living thing with goodwill.*
>
> Tehillim 145:15–16

> ואמר בעתו. לשון יחיד כי כל מין ומין יש לו עת ידוע יזדמן בו מאכלו
>
> *And he said "in its time," in the singular, for each and every kind has a known time in which its food is made ready for it.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 145:15

Radak notices a small grammatical point with a large meaning. The verse says *be'ito*, "in its time," in the singular. Each kind of creature has its own time when its food comes. Provision is not general; it is particular.

> ומשביע לכל חי רצון. כדי פרנסתו הוא משביע את טובו ואת רצונו ואת ברכתו
>
> *"And satisfies every living thing with goodwill": with enough for his sustenance He satisfies him with His goodness, His goodwill and His blessing.*
>
> Rashi on Tehillim 145:16

Rashi adds the measure: "with enough for his sustenance." The verse does not promise luxury. It promises enough, given with goodness and goodwill.

> עיני - עם מדינות המלך מפרנסים המלך והשם לבדו מפרנס הכל, לתת לכל אחד מהם מאכלו בעתו
>
> *"The eyes of all": the people of a king's provinces support the king, and Hashem alone supports all, giving each one of them its food in its time.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:15

Ibn Ezra again draws the contrast with a king. In a human state, the people of the provinces feed the king through their taxes and their labour. Hashem feeds everyone and needs nothing back.

Ordinary provision in Jerusalem

For a household in Jerusalem on 10 November 2026 these verses are not abstract. Shipping through Hormuz is restricted, prices of fuel and freight have moved, and the news each morning carries reports of tankers struck. Yet the bread arrives at the grocery, the buses run, and children go to school. That quiet continuity is itself what the verse describes. “You give them their food in its time.” Most of the time, we do not notice.

The psalm asks us to notice. It also asks us not to confuse the means with the source. A supply chain is a means. A navy escorting tankers is a means. A pipeline that bypasses the strait is a means. All of them are good, and none of them is the open hand.

Righteous in all His ways

> צדיק ה' בכל־דרכיו וחסיד בכל־מעשיו
>
> *Hashem is righteous in all His ways and kind in all His deeds.*
>
> Tehillim 145:17

> צדיק - אם טען טוען למה יאכיל אחד חטה ואחד שעורים? והנה התשובה: כי הוא יודע הטוב להם כי הוא בראם וידע תולדתם, כמו הרופא המצוה שיאכל כל אדם מה שהוא טוב לו. ועוד: כי השם כל מה שיתן בדרך חסד הוא, כי איננו חיוב עליו על כן: וחסיד
>
> *“Righteous”: if someone should argue, why does He feed one wheat and another barley? Here is the answer: He knows what is good for them, for He created them and knows their nature, like the physician who instructs each person to eat what is good for him. And further: whatever Hashem gives is given by way of kindness, for it is no debt upon Him. That is why [the verse continues] “and kind.”*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:17

Ibn Ezra raises the hardest question about provision: why does one person eat wheat and another barley? His answer has two parts. Hashem knows what each creature needs, the way a physician knows what each patient should eat. And whatever He gives is kindness, not debt.

The sheet asks how this verse measures “any claim that a particular arrangement is itself justice.” That is the right question. Only Hashem is described as *tzaddik bechol derachav*, righteous in all His ways. No arrangement made by people, however good, earns that description. A ceasefire can be wise. A blockade can be argued for. A reopening agreement, if one comes, may be a real blessing. Each one should be

weighed against what it actually does for the people it touches, including the people on the ships. None of them should be called justice itself.

Good to all

חנון ורחום ה' ארך אפים וגדל־חסד

Gracious and merciful is Hashem, slow to anger and great in kindness.
Tehillim 145:8

טוב־ה' לכל ורחמיו על־כל־מעשיו

Hashem is good to all, and His mercies are on all His works.
Tehillim 145:9

אפי' למיני החיות והבהמות והעופות הוא טוב ומרחם וכן ראוי לאדם ללכת בדרכיו אלה ואין לו להשחית החיים כי אם לצורך או להשמר מנזקיהם

Even to the kinds of wild animals, cattle and birds He is good and merciful. And so it is fitting for a person to walk in these ways of His, and not to destroy living things except for a need or to guard against the harm they do.
Radak on Tehillim 145:9

Radak draws a practical law from "His mercies are on all His works." Hashem is good even to wild animals, cattle and birds. A person should walk in His ways, and so should not destroy living things except for a real need or to guard against harm. Mercy that reaches the animals is a measure for the mercy we owe to human beings in distress, including sailors far from home.

Near to all who call in truth

קרוב ה' לכל־קראיו לכל אשר יקראהו באמת

Hashem is near to all who call Him, to all who call Him in truth.
Tehillim 145:18

קרוב ה' לכל קוראיו. מאיזה עם שיהיה ובלבד שיקראוהו באמת שפיו ולבו שוים

"Hashem is near to all who call Him": from whatever people he may be, provided that they call Him in truth, that his mouth and his heart are equal.
Radak on Tehillim 145:18

באמת. רוצה לומר בלב שיהיה פיו ולבו שווים ולא יכחיש הלב מאמר פיו

"In truth": that is, with the heart, so that his mouth and his heart are equal, and the heart does not deny what the mouth says.
Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:18

קרוב - אם המלך יהיה רחוק לא יכול להושיע קוראיו והשם לעולם קרוב הוא, רק לאשר יקראוהו באמת ולא לנסותו ואשר איננו ראוי להושיעו

"Near": if the king is far away, he cannot save those who call him; but Hashem is always near — only to those who call Him in truth, and not to test Him, and not to one who is not fit to be saved.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:18

Three commentators agree on one condition: the call must be in truth, mouth and heart the same. Radak adds that this holds "from whatever people he may be." Ibn Ezra contrasts the King who is always near with a human king who may be too far away to save.

This verse also sets a standard for public speech, which we will meet again in the chapter on Kuntres Acharon. A statement that the mouth makes and the heart does not mean is not a call "in truth." Leaders on every side of the present crisis speak every day. We cannot see into anyone's heart, and the laws of speech forbid us to guess at motives. What we can do is hold our own words to this verse.

All flesh

תהלת ה' ידבר־פי ויברך כל־בשר שם קדשו לעולם ועד

My mouth will speak the praise of Hashem, and all flesh will bless His holy name for ever and ever.

Tehillim 145:21

תהלת ה' ידבר פי. וגם כל בשר יברך את שם קדשו לעולם ועד

"My mouth will speak the praise of Hashem": and also all flesh will bless His holy name for ever and ever.

Rashi on Tehillim 145:21

The psalm ends where it began, with David's own mouth, and then widens: "all flesh will bless His holy name." Rashi's comment simply joins the two halves. One person's praise opens into everyone's. That is the pattern the last five psalms will follow, ending with "let every soul praise."

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Metzudas David distinguishes catching the one who is falling from lifting the one already bent. Which of these is harder for a community to do? Which do we do better?

2. Ibn Ezra says every king “lowers this one and raises that one.” Is that a criticism of rulers or simply a description? What follows for how we judge them?
3. The trackers disagree about how many ships cross the strait. Why does it matter, for a booklet like this one, to say so plainly rather than choose the most dramatic figure?
4. “With enough for his sustenance.” What would change in your household if “enough” were the measure?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.14
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.145.14.1
- Radak on Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.14.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145.14.1
- Tehillim 145:15–16: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.15-16
- Radak on Tehillim 145:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.15.1
- Rashi on Tehillim 145:16: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.145.16.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145.15.1
- Tehillim 145:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.17
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145.17.1
- Tehillim 145:8: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.8
- Tehillim 145:9: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.9
- Radak on Tehillim 145:9: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.9.1
- Tehillim 145:18: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.18
- Radak on Tehillim 145:18: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.18.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:18: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.145.18.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:18: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145.18.1
- Tehillim 145:21: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145.21
- Rashi on Tehillim 145:21: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.145.21.1

CHAPTER 3

Do Not Trust in Princes: The Mandate and Its Days

Tehillim 146:1–5 with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David, and the mandate given on 8 November 2026

Topics from the sheet: 3. Warning of Psalm 146:3–4 against trust in princes; 20. Psalm 146:5 help is the G-d of Jacob; 24. CEC presentation and mandate process as human plans that perish

The first Halleluyah

Tehillim 146 is the first of the five psalms that open and close with Halleluyah. Radak noticed the frame and called it a sign of "the greatness of praise."

אלה הששה מזמורים עד סוף הספר הם כולם תהילת [ה'] יתברך ושבחו לפיכך החל בהם ומשלים בהם בתהילה לגודל התהילה וזה המזמור תחילת הפסוק הראשון תהילה ותחילת הפסוק האחרון תהילה והחמשה הללו-[ה'] בראש ובסוף והכל לגודל התהילה ומתי תהיה תהילת [ה'] גדולה, בקבוץ גליות שיראו כל העם הנפלאות שיעשה עם ישראל לפיכך הזכיר בהם קיבוץ גליות ובנין ירושלים

These six psalms, to the end of the book, are all the praise of G-d, may He be blessed, and His glory. So he began with them and completes [the book] with them in praise, because of the greatness of praise. This psalm: the beginning of its first verse is "praise" and the beginning of its last verse is "praise," and the five [that follow] have Halleluyah at the beginning and the end, all because of the greatness of praise. And when will the praise of G-d be great? At the ingathering of the exiles, when all the peoples see the wonders He will do with Israel. That is why he mentioned in them the ingathering of the exiles and the building of Jerusalem.

Radak on Tehillim 145:1

The psalm begins with a promise of lifelong praise, and then, in its third verse, turns with almost no warning to a warning.

הללו-[ה'] הללי נפשי את־ה' אהללה ה' בחיי אזמרה לאלקי בעודי

Halleluyah. Praise Hashem, O my soul. I will praise Hashem while I live; I will sing to my G-d while I exist.

Tehillim 146:1–2

אל־תבטחו בנדיבים בבן־אדם שאין לו תשועה תצא רוחו ישב לאדמתו ביום ההוא אבדו עשתנתיו

Do not trust in princes, in a human being, who has no salvation. His breath goes out, he returns to his earth; on that day his plans are lost.

Tehillim 146:3–4

Do not trust in princes

The word *nedivim* means nobles, the generous, the great. The verse does not say they are wicked. It says they are human, *ben adam she'ein lo teshu'ah*, a person who has no salvation. Ibn Ezra notes two ways to read that phrase and prefers the harder one.

אל - יש אומרים: בבן אדם שאין לו תשועת אמת להושיעכם. והנכון בעיני: בבן אדם שלא יוכל להושיע נפשו

"Do not [trust]": some say, in a human being who has no true salvation to save you. And what is correct in my eyes: in a human being who cannot save himself.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:3

The plain reading is that a human being cannot save you. The deeper reading is that he cannot even save himself. The next verse supports the second: his breath goes out, he returns to his earth, and on that day his *eshtonot*, his plans, are lost.

תצא. כי כאשר תצא ממנו רוח החיוני אז ישוב אל האדמה אשר נלקח ממנה וביום ההוא אבדו כל מחשבותיו כי איננו להוציאם אל הפועל ומה א"כ בטחונו

"Goes out": for when the living spirit goes out of him, he returns to the earth from which he was taken, and on that day all his thoughts are lost, for he is no longer there to bring them into action. So what, then, is his trust worth?

Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:4

Metzudas David draws the conclusion in a question: "So what, then, is his trust worth?" A plan is only as strong as the life of the one who holds it.

ואיך תהיה לאדם תשועה והנה איננו שליט ברוחו לכלות את רוחו, כי תצא רוחו פתע, וישוב לאדמתו ומה שיחשב לעשות לא יוכל כי הנה יצאה רוחו המעמידה אותו והנה ביום מותו אבדו עשתנותיו רוצה לומר מחשבותיו

And how can a person have salvation, when he does not rule over his own spirit, to hold back his spirit? For his spirit goes out suddenly, and he returns to his earth, and what he planned to do he cannot do. … On the day of his death his "eshtonot" are lost, that is, his thoughts.

Radak on Tehillim 146:4 (one clause omitted in English)

Radak puts it more starkly still. A person does not rule over his own spirit. His plans may be good, but he cannot guarantee that he will be there to carry them out.

What the verse does not forbid

It would be a misreading to take this psalm as contempt for government or for the people who serve in it. Radak is careful here, and his comment is the key to the whole chapter.

> אלא אם יבטח באדם ישים העיקר [ה'] יתברך שיתן בלב האדם הנדיב בעזרו וכפל הענין במלות שונות שאין לו תשועה שאם לא ברצון [ה'], אין ביד האדם להושיע חבירו מצרתו כי לה' לבדו התשועה והוא יסובבנה על יד בני אדם המו שסיבב תשועת גלות בבל על ידי כורש
>
> *Rather, if he trusts in a person, let him make the main thing G-d, may He be blessed, who puts it into the heart of the generous person to help him. … For if not by the will of G-d, it is not in a person's hand to save his fellow from his trouble, for salvation is Hashem's alone, and He brings it about through human beings, as He brought about the salvation from the Babylonian exile through Koresh.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 146:3 (one clause omitted)

Trust in a person is allowed, so long as the main trust is placed in G-d, "who puts it into the heart of the generous person to help." Salvation belongs to Hashem alone, and He brings it about through human beings. Radak's example is Koresh, the Persian king through whom the exiles came home from Babylon. Koresh was a prince. He was also the means.

That is a balanced teaching and a useful one. The psalm does not tell us to ignore the President, the candidate, the Knesset or the mediators. It tells us where to put the weight.

The mandate and the consultations

The sheet ties these verses to the first mandate of the 26th Knesset. The order of events, from opened reporting, is this.

- Wednesday 4 November 2026: the Central Elections Committee published the official final results.
- Wednesday and Thursday, 4–5 November: President Herzog held consultations with all the Knesset factions. The Times of Israel reports that factions totalling 67 members recommended Gadi Eisenkot and 46 recommended Benjamin Netanyahu, and that United Torah Judaism, with seven seats, made no recommendation.
- Saturday night, 7 November: the President announced that he would give the mandate to Eisenkot.
- Sunday 8 November, 17:00: the formal ceremony at the President's Residence. Eisenkot has 28 days, with a possible extension of up to 14.

- Tuesday 10 November: the 26th Knesset was sworn in. No government had been formed.

Each step in that list is a human act, done according to law, by people who were chosen for the task. Each step is also, in the language of the psalm, *eshtonot*, plans. The verse does not mock them. It reminds us that they belong to the people who make them, and that people are mortal.

This applies evenly. It applies to the candidate who holds the mandate, to the rival who hopes for the next one, to the President who granted it, and to every party in the consultations. Nothing in the verse favours one of them. It asks the same thing of the citizen in every case: do not put your whole trust here.

Happy is the one whose help is the G-d of Yaakov

> אשרי ש[ה'] יעקב בעזרו שברו על־ה' אלקיו
>
> *Happy is the one whose help is the G-d of Yaakov, whose hope is in Hashem his G-d,*
> Tehillim 146:5

> אשרי. מי ש[ה'] יעקב בעזרו, שהבטיחו הקדוש ברוך הוא "הנה אנכי עמך ושמרתיך והשיבתיך" (בראשית כח:טו). ולמה אשריו? לפי שהוא עושה שמים וארץ ואת הים, וכיון שהכל שלו, יש בידו לשמרו בים
>
> *"Happy": is the one whose help is the G-d of Yaakov, for the Holy One, blessed be He, promised him, "Behold, I am with you and will guard you … and bring you back" (Bereishis 28:15). And why is he happy? Because He makes heaven and earth and the sea, and since everything is His, it is in His power to guard him at sea and on dry land. But a king who serves idols, if he guards him on dry land, cannot guard him at sea.*
> Rashi on Tehillim 146:5

Rashi explains why Yaakov in particular. Hashem promised him, as he fled from home with nothing, "I am with you and will guard you … and bring you back." And then Rashi gives a reason that reads, on this day, almost as if it were written for the news. Hashem made heaven and earth and the sea, so He can guard a person at sea and on dry land. A human king who guards him on land cannot guard him at sea.

The sheet links this verse to the posture of a person "while human princes negotiate." Rashi's comment shows that posture. It is not passive. Yaakov went to Charan, worked for twenty years, and came home with a family. His trust was in Hashem, and his hands were busy the whole time.

> אשרי - הטעם שלא ישען רק על השם לבדו ולא יבקש עזר מאדם
>
> *"Happy": the meaning is that he leans only on Hashem alone and does not ask help from a human being.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:5

> ה' - הנה הטעם אין ראוי להשען אדם על אדם ואם אדם יחזק ממנו, ישען עליו בתפלתו אל השם
>
> *"Hashem...": the meaning is that it is not fitting for a person to lean on a person; and if a person is stronger than he is, let him lean, in his prayer, on Hashem.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:8

Ibn Ezra gives the rule plainly: a person should lean on Hashem alone and not ask help of a human being. Then he softens it, or rather explains it. If another person is stronger than you, lean on him "in your prayer, on Hashem." That is a remarkable line. The help of the stronger person is real, but the leaning happens in prayer.

The order of the work

The sheet says that the verse "orders the work of negotiation." That is the best phrase on the page. Trust does not replace the work. It puts the work in order.

A coalition negotiator still has to count to 61. A mediator still has to carry messages. A voter still has to vote, and a citizen still has to read the news carefully. What changes is what each of them expects at the end. If the plans succeed, the success is a gift through people. If they fail, the failure does not touch the One whose help is the G-d of Yaakov.

That is why this psalm is said every morning, before the day's work begins, and not only on days of crisis.

The presentation to the President

One more detail in the sheet deserves a line. Topic 24 speaks of "the official CEC presentation to the President and subsequent mandate" as human plans that perish "unless ordered toward justice." The phrase is the sheet's own, not the psalm's, and it should be read carefully. The election results are not plans in the sense of the verse. They are a record of what millions of people did on one day. The plans begin afterwards, in the consultations and the negotiations. Those are the *eshtonot* that the verse says may be lost. The results themselves stand as a fact.

That distinction matters for anyone who writes about the election. A fact is reported as it was published. A plan is described as a plan, with the people who hold it named and their words quoted, and with no guess at what is in their hearts.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 146

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 הללו-[ה'] הללי נפשי את־ה'

Hallelujah.
Praise the L-RD, O my soul!

2 אהללה ה' בחיי אזמרה לאלקי בעודי

I will praise the L-RD all my life,
sing hymns to my G-d while I exist.

3 אל־תבטחו בנדיבים בבן־אדם שאין לו תשועה

Put not your trust in the great,
in mortal man who cannot save.

4 תצא רוחו ישב לאדמתו ביום ההוא אבדו עשתנתיו

His breath departs;
he returns to the dust;
on that day his plans come to nothing.

5 אשרי ש[ה'] יעקב בעזרו שברו על־ה' אלקיו

Happy is he who has the G-d of Jacob for his help,
whose hope is in the L-RD his G-d,

6 עשה שמים וארץ את־הים ואת־כל־אשר־בם השמר אמת לעולם

maker of heaven and earth,
the sea and all that is in them;
who keeps faith forever;

7 עשה משפט לעשוקים נתן לחם לרעבים ה' מתיר אסורים

who secures justice for those who are wronged,
gives food to the hungry.
The L-RD sets prisoners free;

8 ה' פקח עורים ה' זקף כפופים ה' אהב צדיקים

The L-RD restores sight to the blind;
the L-RD makes those who are bent stand straight;
the L-RD loves the righteous;

9 ה' שמר את־גרים יתום ואלמנה יעודד ודרך רשעים יעות

The L-RD watches over the stranger;
He gives courage to the orphan and widow,
but makes the path of the wicked tortuous.

10 ימלך ה' לעולם אלקיך ציון לדר ודר הללו-[ה']

The L-RD shall reign forever,
your G-d, O Zion, for all generations.
Hallelujah.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Ibn Ezra prefers the reading "a human being cannot save even himself." Why might that reading be harder, and also kinder, than the plain one?
2. Radak says one may trust a person if "the main thing" is G-d. What does that look like in practice for a voter, a candidate or a soldier?
3. Rashi says a human king can guard on land but not at sea. Where in your own life do you rely on help that has a limit like that?
4. What is the difference between a fact, such as the election results, and a plan, such as a coalition? Why does the psalm warn only about the second?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Radak on Tehillim 145:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145.1.1
- Tehillim 146:1–2: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.1-2
- Tehillim 146:3–4: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.3-4
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:3: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.146.3.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.146.4.1
- Radak on Tehillim 146:4 (one clause omitted in English): https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.146.4.1
- Radak on Tehillim 146:3 (one clause omitted): https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.146.3.1
- Tehillim 146:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.5
- Rashi on Tehillim 146:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.146.5.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.146.5.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:8: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.146.8.1

CHAPTER 4

He Keeps Faith Forever: The Sea, the Bound and the Reign

Tehillim 146:6–10 with Rashi, Radak and Metzudas David, and the Strait of Hormuz in November 2026

Topics from the sheet: 4. Psalm 146:7–9 as covenantal measure for Hormuz reopening conditions; 28. Psalm 146:6 sea under the One who keeps faith forever; 29. Release of the bound in Psalm 146:7 and status of vessels; 47. Psalm 146:10 Hashem will reign forever

The sea in the middle of the verse

Tehillim 146 moves from the warning about princes to a list of what Hashem does. The list begins with creation and ends with kingship. In between, almost every line names a kind of person in trouble.

עשה שמים וארץ את־הים ואת־כל־אשר־בם השמר אמת לעולם

Maker of heaven and earth, the sea and all that is in them, who keeps faith forever,
Tehillim 146:6

The sea appears in the middle of the first line: heaven, earth, *the sea and all that is in them*. Rashi, as we saw, made this the reason a person is happy to rely on the G-d of Yaakov: He alone guards at sea and on land. The verse then adds a phrase that governs everything after it: *hashomer emes le'olam*, who keeps faith forever.

השומר אמת לעולם. לסוף דורות רבים הוא מקים ושומר אמתת הבטחתו

"Who keeps faith forever": to the end of many generations He fulfils and keeps the truth of His promise.
Rashi on Tehillim 146:6

והוא השומר אמת לעולם ששומר הבטחתו לזמן רב

And He is the One "who keeps faith forever," who keeps His promise for a long time.
Radak on Tehillim 146:6

Rashi and Radak read *emes* here as the truth of a promise. Hashem keeps His word "to the end of many generations," "for a long time." The faithfulness is measured in centuries.

Whose claim is permanent?

The sheet asks whether any party's claim to manage the Strait of Hormuz can be treated as permanent. The verse answers by contrast. Permanence belongs to the One who made the sea. Every human claim over it is, by that standard, temporary.

The present claims are serious and are being made in public. Iran's proposal to end the war, as reported by Reuters on 10 November 2026, ties the end of its own blockade of the strait to an end of the US blockade of Iranian ports, the lifting of some sanctions and a halt to bombing, with talks on its nuclear programme to follow. The United States has rejected that plan. President Trump said, in the same report, that he intends to keep the naval blockade in place for now and to hold off on new strikes. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps has spoken of tankers on "unauthorised routes," and Gulf News noted on 10 November that its claims about tankers struck are unverified. The United States, for its part, coordinates the transits it facilitates: about 30 a day from 5 to 7 November, according to US naval shipping-coordination data, which UKMTO says it cannot independently verify.

So each side asserts a kind of management of the water. Each speaks as though the arrangement it wants should last. The psalm's phrase sets all of them in proportion. Only One keeps faith forever. Every other arrangement over the sea is a stage.

That is not a political position. It does not say which side is right about the strait, or what a fair settlement would be. It says that whatever is agreed, if anything is agreed, will be a human arrangement and should be spoken of as one.

Justice for the oppressed, bread for the hungry

> עשה משפט לעשוקים נתן לחם לרעבים ה' מתיר אסורים
>
> *who does justice for the oppressed, gives bread to the hungry; Hashem releases the bound.*
> Tehillim 146:7

> עושה משפט לעשוקים. בכל דור ודור עושה משפט בעבורם בעושקיהם
>
> *"Who does justice for the oppressed": in each and every generation He does justice on their behalf against those who oppress them.*
> Radak on Tehillim 146:7

Radak reads the present tense as a habit: *bechol dor vador*, in each and every generation, Hashem does justice for the oppressed against those who oppress them. He applies it to Israel in Babylon, but the principle is general.

The sheet proposes this verse as a "covenantal measure" for any reopening agreement. That is a good use of it. Before asking whether an agreement is a victory for one side,

ask the questions of the verse. Does it relieve the people who are wronged? Does it bring bread to the hungry? Does it release anyone who is bound?

These are not rhetorical questions. Shipping is how food, fuel and medicine reach people across the region and beyond. An agreement that opens the water would touch millions of ordinary lives. An agreement that only moves the restriction from one party to another would leave the verse unanswered.

Releasing the bound

> מתיר. פותח קשרי האסורים במאסר וישלחם חפשי
>
> *"Releases": He opens the bonds of those bound in prison and sends them out free.*
>
> Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:7

Matir asurim: He opens the bonds of those in prison and sends them out free. The sheet links this line to the status of ships held or delayed under the present restriction, and to their crews.

The reporting opened for this booklet gives some sense of what "bound" means at sea in November 2026. The National reported on 9 November that around 400 ships carrying about 6,000 seafarers had been stuck at sea since July, as of late October. Ben Bailey of the Mission to Seafarers told the paper that some crews are surrounded by other vessels and by mines, "so they can't go forwards, and they can't go back." A study by the Nordland Research Institute in Norway, published from a survey of seafarers in the Gulf, describes crews who stayed on board after their contracts had ended. Gulf News reported on 10 November that on 7 November a tanker was struck off Khasab in Oman and its crew was safe, and that another tanker nearby was on fire and its crew evacuated.

Those are the bound of this season. They are not soldiers or negotiators. Most of them come from countries far from the conflict. The verse that blesses Hashem as *matir asurim* every morning includes them.

The sheet's question is whether present measures "release or further bind." That question can be asked of every measure by every party, without assuming anyone's motives. It is the question the verse itself asks.

Straightening the bent, guarding the stranger

> ה' פקח עורים ה' זקף כפופים ה' אהב צדיקים ה' שמר את־גרים יתום ואלמנה יעודד ודרך רשעים יעות

Hashem opens the eyes of the blind; Hashem straightens the bent; Hashem loves the righteous. Hashem guards the strangers; He upholds the orphan and the widow, and the way of the wicked He twists.

Tehillim 146:8–9

> זוקף כפופים. האנשים הכפופים לארץ בשפל המצב המקום ב"ה זוקף אותם לעמוד זקוף ברום המעלה

"Straightens the bent": people bent to the ground in a low condition, the Omnipresent, blessed be He, straightens them to stand upright at a high level.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:8

Metzudas David takes *zokef kefufim* as social: people bent low "in a low condition" are lifted to stand upright at a high level. The list continues with the stranger, the orphan and the widow, the three figures the Torah protects again and again because they have no one else.

The stranger, *ger*, is the one far from home. On this day the word fits the foreign crews in the Gulf, the workers far from their families, and anyone caught in a war that is not theirs. "Commercial vessels in our region are caught in a war that they have nothing to do with," the head of one Gulf shipping group told The National. The psalm says Hashem guards them.

Hashem will reign forever

> ימלך ה' לעולם אלקיך ציון לדר ודר הללו-[ה']

Hashem will reign forever, your G-d, O Zion, for generation after generation. Halleluyah.

Tehillim 146:10

> ימלך ה' לעולם. יקים את מלכותו בשמירת בניו

"Hashem will reign forever": He will establish His kingship by guarding His children.

Rashi on Tehillim 146:10

The psalm ends with kingship. Rashi explains how the kingship is shown: "by guarding His children." Not by display, but by protection.

The sheet sets this verse beside "the temporary character of any single Knesset or any single blockade." A Knesset is elected for a term. A blockade is declared for a purpose and lifted when the purpose changes. Both are real. Both will end. The closing verse of

the psalm does not say they are unimportant. It says they happen inside a reign that does not end.

There is comfort in that, and there is also a discipline. The comfort is that no arrangement, however painful, has the last word. The discipline is that no arrangement, however welcome, should be treated as if it did.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Rashi and Radak read “who keeps faith forever” as faithfulness to a promise over many generations. Which promises of the Torah have you seen kept in your own lifetime?
2. Iran, the United States and others each describe the arrangement they want in the strait. What would it mean to speak of every such arrangement as temporary, without taking sides?
3. The verse lists the oppressed, the hungry and the bound. If you were drafting an agreement, how would you test it against this list?
4. Why do you think Rashi says Hashem’s kingship is shown “by guarding His children” rather than by power?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 146:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.6
- Rashi on Tehillim 146:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.146.6.1
- Radak on Tehillim 146:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.146.6.1
- Tehillim 146:7: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.7
- Radak on Tehillim 146:7: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.146.7.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:7: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.146.7.2
- Tehillim 146:8–9: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.8-9
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:8: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.146.8.1
- Tehillim 146:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.146.10
- Rashi on Tehillim 146:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.146.10.1

CHAPTER 5

Builder of Jerusalem: Stars, Horses and the Humble

Tehillim 147 with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David

Topics from the sheet: 5. Psalm 147:2–3 gathering the dispersed and household stability; 6. Numbering of the stars in Psalm 147:4 vs limited human plans; 30. Psalm 147:10–11 not in strength of the horse but those who fear Him; 31. Building of Jerusalem in Psalm 147:2 and ordinary communal life

A psalm of building

Tehillim 147 is a psalm of Jerusalem. It opens with the city being built and the dispersed being gathered, and it returns to Jerusalem in its second half. In between it moves from the stars to the rain to the young ravens, and it pauses once, sharply, to say what Hashem does not delight in.

> בונה ירושלם ה' נדחי ישראל יכנס הרפא לשבורי לב ומחבש לעצבותם
>
> *Hashem is the builder of Jerusalem; He gathers the dispersed of Israel. He heals the broken-hearted and binds up their wounds.*
>
> Tehillim 147:2–3

Builder of Jerusalem

The verb is a present participle: *boneh,* building. Metzudas David reads it as a promise.

> בונה. הוא הבונה לעתיד את ירושלים ואת ישראל הנדחים בקצה הארץ יכנס אליה
>
> *"Builder": He is the One who will build Jerusalem in the future, and Israel, dispersed to the end of the earth, He will gather into her.*
>
> Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:2

Ibn Ezra notes that the whole psalm is said "by way of prophecy," as though the poet already saw the building.

[[ie147_1]] Radak, in his opening comment on the six psalms, connects the praise of this section to the ingathering of the exiles and the building of Jerusalem.

The sheet reads the verse in two directions. One is the great building of the future. The other is small and daily: the building of ordinary communal life. Both are true to the verse, and the second needs saying on a day like this one. Jerusalem on 10 November 2026 is a city with a parliament newly sworn in and no government yet formed, with a

war at sea that has gone on for more than eight months, and with a great deal of ordinary life going on regardless. On a Rosh Chodesh morning, shuls say Hallel and children go to school. Families of the new members of the Knesset came up for the ceremony, and the Jerusalem Post reported that each new member was given a flower for his or her lapel.

That kind of life is also building. Rebuilding is local and daily, the sheet says, and that is right. A city is built by the people who keep living in it.

He heals the broken-hearted

The second half of the verse is the gentlest line in the psalm: *harofei lishvurei lev,* He heals the broken-hearted and binds up their wounds. Ibn Ezra identifies the broken-hearted as the mourners of Zion. Radak applies it to Israel in exile, "broken-hearted and sad."

> הרופא לשבורי לב - הם אבילי ציון
>
> *"He heals the broken-hearted": these are the mourners of Zion.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:3

> לשבורי לב. כמו ישראל שהם שבורי לב ועצבים בגלות
>
> *"The broken-hearted": like Israel, who are broken-hearted and sad in exile.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 147:3

This line belongs to the household as much as to the nation. There are families in Israel this autumn who are broken-hearted in the plainest sense: families of soldiers who fell, families of those murdered on 7 October 2023, families waiting for news. A psalm of building that did not include them would not be a psalm of Jerusalem. The order of the verse matters. Building first, gathering next, and then the healing of hearts. The city is not finished until its broken-hearted are cared for.

He counts the stars

> מונה מספר לכוכבים לכלם שמות יקרא גדול אדונינו ורב־כח לתבונתו אין מספר
>
> *He counts the number of the stars; He calls them all by name. Great is our L-rd and abundant in power; His understanding has no number.*
>
> Tehillim 147:4–5

מונה - בעבור שהזכיר נדחי ישראל שהם מפוזרים בכל הארץ, הזכיר כנגד זה: מונה מספר לכוכבים שהכוכבים הם מפוזרים בגלגל העליון והוא ידעם כולם

"Counts": because he mentioned the dispersed of Israel, who are scattered across the whole earth, he mentioned opposite it, "He counts the number of the stars," for the stars are scattered in the highest sphere, and He knows them all.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:4

Ibn Ezra explains why the stars come right after the dispersed of Israel. The exiles are scattered across the earth; the stars are scattered across the sky. Hashem knows each one by name. No one is lost to Him in the scattering.

כי מלך בשר ודם שיש עליו להנהיג מדינות רבות ילאה להנהיגם כולם כאחד הקרובות אליו והרחוקות ממנו ואם ינהיג הקרובות אליו על סדר הנכון לא עשה כן ברחוקות שילאה כחו בזה ואם יהיה בו הכח לא תהיה בו התבונה, אבל אדונינו הוא מנהיג את כל העולם הנהגה ישרה כי הכח והתבונה בו שהוא גדול ורב כח

For a king of flesh and blood who must govern many provinces will grow weary of governing them all as one, those near him and those far from him. If he governs those near him in proper order, he will not do so with those far away, for his strength will tire of it; and if he has the strength, he will not have the understanding. But our L-rd governs the whole world with an upright governance, for strength and understanding are in Him, for He is great and abundant in power.

Radak on Tehillim 147:5

Radak's comment on the next verse is one of the most useful passages in this booklet for thinking about government. A king of flesh and blood, he says, grows weary of governing many provinces at once. If he governs the near ones well, he neglects the far ones. If he has the strength, he lacks the understanding. Only Hashem has both strength and understanding without limit.

This is not cynicism about rulers. It is realism. The sheet sets this verse beside "Iranian conditions and American statements of momentum," and the pairing works because of Radak. Every party to the present crisis has a plan, and every plan is the plan of a power that is limited in strength, in understanding, or in both. On 10 November 2026, President Trump spoke of "positive momentum" in efforts to end the war, according to the Times of Israel and Reuters; Iran's top security official, Mohsen Rezaei, spoke of "imaginary talks"; Qatar's prime minister called his talks in Washington positive. Each statement is a reading of the situation by people who cannot see all of it. The larger accounting, as the sheet puts it, belongs to the One who counts the stars.

המכסה שמים בעבים המכין לארץ מטר המצמיח הרים חציר נותן לבהמה לחמה לבני ערב אשר יקראו

Who covers the heavens with clouds, prepares rain for the earth, makes the mountains sprout grass; who gives the animal its food, to the young ravens that call.

Tehillim 147:8–9

Between the stars and the horse, the psalm stops for rain, grass and the young ravens that call. The One who counts the stars also feeds the smallest creatures, and on time. The same chapter that speaks of the building of Jerusalem speaks of a raven's breakfast.

He lifts the humble

ואף על פי שהוא גדול ורב כח הוא משגיח על הענוים והשפלים והחלושים ומנשא אותם ומשפיל הרשעים המתגאים עדי ארץ ובזמן הזה אינו עושה זה, כי פעמים יצליחו הרשעים אבל לעתיד יעשה זה על דרך השלמות

And although He is great and abundant in power, He watches over the humble, the lowly and the weak, and lifts them up, and lowers the wicked who exalt themselves to the ground. In this time He does not [always] do this, for sometimes the wicked succeed; but in the future He will do it in full.

Radak on Tehillim 147:6

Radak is honest about the present. Hashem lifts the humble and lowers the proud, "but in this time He does not [always] do this, for sometimes the wicked succeed." The full working-out is for the future. A reader who expects every headline to show divine justice will be disappointed, and Radak warns him in advance.

Not in the strength of the horse

לא בגבורת הסוס יחפץ לא־בשוקי האיש ירצה רוצה ה' את־יראיו את־המיחלים לחסדו

Not in the strength of the horse does He delight, nor in the legs of a man does He take pleasure. Hashem takes pleasure in those who fear Him, in those who hope for His kindness.

Tehillim 147:10–11

לא בשוקי האיש ירצה. ולא בקלות מרוצת שוקי האיש ירצה:

"Nor in the legs of a man does He take pleasure": nor does He want the swiftness of the running of a man's legs.

Rashi on Tehillim 147:10

פירושו שאינו חפץ באדם שבוטח בגבורת הסוס וכן מי שבוטח לברוח מן המלחמה

Its meaning is that He does not delight in a person who trusts in the strength of the horse, and likewise one who trusts [in it] to flee from battle.

Radak on Tehillim 147:10

לא בגבורת. אינו חפץ במי שתולה בטחונו בגבורת הסוס לרוץ ולרדוף במלחמה: לא בשוקי. לא ירצה במי שבוטח בחוזק שוקיו לרוץ רגלי: רוצה. רק רוצה ה' ביריאיו וחוזר ומפרש שהם המיחלים לחסדו ואינם בוטחים בעצמם בחוזק השוק או בגבורת הסוס כי הבוטח באלו מסיר יראת ה' מעל פניו

"Not in the strength": He does not delight in one who hangs his trust on the strength of the horse to run and pursue in war. "Nor in the legs": He does not take pleasure in one who trusts the strength of his legs to run on foot. "Takes pleasure": Hashem takes pleasure only in those who fear Him; and the verse goes back and explains that these are the ones who hope for His kindness and do not trust in themselves, in the strength of the leg or the might of the horse, for one who trusts in these removes the fear of Hashem from before him.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:10–11

לא - הטעם אין חפץ השם בגבורה רק ביראתו

"Not": the meaning is that Hashem does not delight in strength, only in the fear of Him.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:10

Four commentators, one teaching. The horse is the strongest military animal of the ancient world; the legs of a man are the runner, the infantryman. Hashem does not delight in either. Metzudas David explains that what He does not delight in is the person who "hangs his trust" on them, because "one who trusts in these removes the fear of Hashem from before him." Ibn Ezra reduces it to a single line: Hashem does not delight in strength, only in the fear of Him.

The sheet links these verses to "statements of naval strength or blockade capacity." In November 2026 there are many such statements. The US president has called the blockade "the Greatest Naval Blockade in History"; Iran's forces announce the ships they have struck. The psalm does not say that strength is useless. Armies defend, navies escort, and Israel has needed both. It says that strength is not what Hashem prizes, and that trust placed in it pushes out something more important.

For a Jew in Jerusalem, the verse is not only about other people's armies. It is about our own. Every morning, in Pesukei deZimra, we say that Hashem does not delight in the strength of the horse. We say it while our sons serve. The verse does not rebuke them; it reminds all of us where their protection, and ours, finally comes from.

Praise Hashem, O Jerusalem

> שבחי ירושלם את־ה' הללי אלקיך ציון כי־חזק בריחי שעריך ברך בניך בקרבך השם־גבולך שלום חלב חטים ישביעך

Praise Hashem, O Jerusalem; praise your G-d, O Zion. For He has strengthened the bars of your gates; He has blessed your children within you. He makes your borders peace; He satisfies you with the finest wheat.

Tehillim 147:12–14

> כי חזק. שלא תפחדי לעולם שיבא עליך אויב כי [ה'] ישמרנה כאילו בריחיה חזקים

"For He has strengthened": so that you will never fear that an enemy will come against you, for G-d will guard her as though her bars were strong.

Radak on Tehillim 147:13

The second half of the psalm returns to the city. Radak reads "He has strengthened the bars of your gates" as a promise that Jerusalem will not need to fear an enemy, "for G-d will guard her as though her bars were strong." The verse that follows is the one every household wants: *hasam gevulech shalom*, He makes your borders peace, and satisfies you with the finest wheat.

That is the order of the blessing. Gates, children, peace at the borders, bread. It is a description of an ordinary good life, and it is one of the highest praises in the book.

The cold and the crumbs

> ומדרש אגדה כפתים הכל לפי משא הבריות: העני לפי חוסר מלבושיו מיקל עליו

And the Midrash Aggadah: "like crumbs" — everything according to what people can bear; for the poor man, according to his lack of clothing, He makes it lighter for him.

Rashi on Tehillim 147:17

One small comment from Rashi deserves a place at the end. On "He casts His ice like crumbs," Rashi brings a Midrash: everything is measured according to what people can bear, and for the poor man, who lacks clothing, Hashem makes the cold lighter. Kislev is the month of the first real cold in Jerusalem. The Midrash asks Hashem to measure the winter by the poor, and it asks us, by implication, to do the same.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 147

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 הללו-[ה'] כי־טוב זמרה אלקינו כי־נעים נאוה תהלה

Hallelujah.
It is good to chant hymns to our G-d;
it is pleasant to sing glorious praise.

2 בונה ירושלם ה' נדחי ישראל יכנס

The L-RD rebuilds Jerusalem;
He gathers in the exiles of Israel.

3 הרפא לשבורי לב ומחבש לעצבותם

He heals their broken hearts,
and binds up their wounds.

4 מונה מספר לכוכבים לכלם שמות יקרא

He reckoned the number of the stars;
to each He gave its name.

5 גדול אדונינו ורב־כח לתבונתו אין מספר

Great is our L-rd and full of power;
His wisdom is beyond reckoning.

6 מעודד ענוים ה' משפיל רשעים עדי־ארץ

The L-RD gives courage to the lowly,
and brings the wicked down to the dust.

7 ענו לה' בתודה זמרו לאלקינו בכנור

Sing to the L-RD a song of praise,
chant a hymn with a lyre to our G-d,

8 המכסה שמים בעבים המכין לארץ מטר המצמיח הרים חציר

who covers the heavens with clouds,
provides rain for the earth,
makes mountains put forth grass;

9 נותן לבהמה לחמה לבני ערב אשר יקראו

who gives the beasts their food,
to the raven's brood what they cry for.

10 לא בגבורת הסוס יחפץ לא־בשוקי האיש ירצה

He does not prize the strength of horses,
nor value the fleetness of men;

11 רוצה ה' את־יראיו את־המיחלים לחסדו

but the L-RD values those who fear Him,
those who depend on His faithful care.

12 שבחי ירושלם את־ה' הללי אלקיך ציון

O Jerusalem, glorify the L-RD;
praise your G-d, O Zion!

13 כי־חזק בריחי שעריך ברך בניך בקרבך

For He made the bars of your gates strong,
and blessed your children within you.

14 השם־גבולך שלום חלב חטים ישביעך

He endows your realm with well-being,
and satisfies you with choice wheat.

15 השלח אמרתו ארץ עד־מהרה ירוץ דברו

He sends forth His word to the earth;
His command runs swiftly.

16 הנתן שלג כצמר כפור כאפר יפזר

He lays down snow like fleece,
scatters frost like ashes.

17 משליך קרחו כפתים לפני קרתו מי יעמד

He tosses down hail like crumbs—
who can endure His icy cold?

18 ישלח דברו וימסם ישב רוחו יזלו־מים

He issues a command—it melts them;
He breathes—the waters flow.

19 מגיד דברו ליעקב חקיו ומשפטיו לישראל

He issued His commands to Jacob,
His statutes and rules to Israel.

20 לא־עשה כן לכל־גוי ומשפטים בל־ידעום הללו־[ה']

He did not do so for any other nation;
of such rules they know nothing.
Hallelujah.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Ibn Ezra pairs the scattered exiles with the scattered stars. Who in your community feels scattered or unseen? What would it mean to “know them by name”?
2. Radak says a human ruler has either the strength or the understanding, but not both without limit. Where have you seen that limit in public life, without blaming anyone for it?
3. Why does the psalm say Hashem does not delight in the horse, in the middle of a list of His kindnesses?
4. “He makes your borders peace.” What would peace at the borders look like for your own household this winter?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 147:2–3: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.147.2-3
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.147.2.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:3: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.147.3.1
- Radak on Tehillim 147:3: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.147.3.1
- Tehillim 147:4–5: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.147.4-5
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.147.4.1
- Radak on Tehillim 147:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.147.5.1
- Tehillim 147:8–9: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.147.8-9
- Radak on Tehillim 147:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.147.6.1
- Tehillim 147:10–11: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.147.10-11
- Rashi on Tehillim 147:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.147.10.2
- Radak on Tehillim 147:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.147.10.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:10–11: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.147.10.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.147.10.1
- Tehillim 147:12–14: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.147.12-14
- Radak on Tehillim 147:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.147.13.1
- Rashi on Tehillim 147:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.147.17.1

CHAPTER 6

Kings of the Earth: Psalm 148 and the Swearing-In

Tehillim 148 with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David, and the opening of the 26th Knesset on 10 November 2026

Topics from the sheet: 7. Psalm 148 cosmic summons and regional mediators; 21. Cosmic praise of Psalms 148–150 and residual local arenas; 32. Psalm 148:11–12 kings and peoples and the swearing-in ceremony; 48. Cosmic praise of Psalm 148 and residual arenas of ordinary life

A summons to everything

Tehillim 148 is a roll call of creation. It starts in the highest heavens and works its way down: angels, hosts, sun and moon, stars, the waters above the sky. Then it turns to the earth: sea creatures and depths, fire and hail, snow and vapour, mountains, trees, animals and birds. Only at the end does it reach human beings, and when it does it names kings first.

הללו-[ה'] הללו את־ה' מן־השמים הללוהו במרומים הללוהו כל־מלאכיו הללוהו כל־צבאו

Halleluyah. Praise Hashem from the heavens; praise Him in the heights. Praise Him, all His angels; praise Him, all His hosts.

Tehillim 148:1–2

וענין הללו אינו מצוה אלא כאילו אמר להם נאה להלל

And the sense of "praise" is not a command; it is as if he said to them: it is fitting to praise.

Radak on Tehillim 148:1

Radak makes a point that frames the whole psalm. "Praise" here is not a command. The sun is not being ordered to do something it might refuse. It is as if the psalmist said: it is fitting to praise. The psalm describes the way things ought to be seen.

A law that will not pass away

יהללו את־שם ה' כי הוא צוה ונבראו ויעמידם לעד לעולם חק־נתן ולא יעבור

Let them praise the name of Hashem, for He commanded and they were created. He set them up for ever and ever; He gave a law that will not pass away.

Tehillim 148:5–6

> חק נתן. בהם, זה ישמש ביום וזה ישמש בלילה ולא יעבור אותו חק
>
> *"He gave a law": in them — this one will serve by day and that one by night, and that law will not pass away.*
>
> Rashi on Tehillim 148:6

> חק נתן. לכל אחד נתן חוק מתי ישמש זה ומתי ישמש זה ולא יעבור החוק ההוא
>
> *"He gave a law": to each one He gave a law, when this one will serve and when that one will serve, and that law will not pass away.*
>
> Metzudas David on Tehillim 148:6

Rashi and Metzudas David read *chok nasan* as the order of creation: this one serves by day, that one by night, and the law does not change. The heavens keep their schedule.

The sheet links this psalm to "mediators as instruments within larger order, not substitutes." The connection is through the stormy wind.

> הללו את־ה' מן־הארץ תנינים וכל־תהמות אש וברד שלג וקיטור רוח סערה עשה דברו
>
> *Praise Hashem from the earth, sea creatures and all the depths; fire and hail, snow and vapour, stormy wind that does His word.*
>
> Tehillim 148:7–8

> רוח סערה. העושה את דברו ושליחותו
>
> *"Stormy wind": that does His word and His errand.*
>
> Rashi on Tehillim 148:8

> ואמר עושה דברו. להודיע כי הוא איננו במקרה אלא הוא מצוה אותו להתנועע ובדברו ובמצותו הוא מתנועע
>
> *And he said "that does His word" to make known that it is not by chance; rather, He commands it to move, and by His word and His command it moves.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 148:8

The stormy wind "does His word." Rashi calls it His messenger. Radak adds that it does not move by chance; it moves because it is commanded. The most violent thing in the list is an agent.

That is a way of seeing every intermediary in the world, including human ones. In November 2026, Qatar's prime minister has carried messages between Washington and Tehran; Reuters, on 10 November, called Qatar "a prime mediator since early in the war." Iran's foreign minister has named Pakistan alongside Qatar in the indirect talks, according to Khaleej Times. Turkey's president, Recep Tayyip Erdogan, said on 9 November that he had told President Trump that Ankara opposed a new wave of attacks on Iran (Al Arabiya). These are real people doing hard and often thankless work. The

psalm does not diminish them. It locates them. A mediator, like the wind, is a messenger within an order larger than himself. He is not sovereign over the outcome. The sheet says it in four words: mediation is not sovereign.

Kings of the earth

> מלכי־ארץ וכל־לאמים שרים וכל־שפטי ארץ בחורים וגם־בתולות זקנים עם־נערים יהללו את־שם ה' כי־נשגב שמו לבדו הודו על־ארץ ושמים

Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all judges of the earth; young men and also maidens, elders with youths: let them praise the name of Hashem, for His name alone is exalted; His splendour is over earth and heaven.

Tehillim 148:11–13

When the psalm reaches people, it lists them by rank and by age: kings, peoples, princes, judges, young men and maidens, elders with youths. Radak notices both lists.

> והזכיר בבני אדם מעלת הכבוד ומעלת הימים ואמר כי כולם יהללו את ה' כנכבד כנקלה כקטון כגדול

And among human beings he mentioned the rank of honour and the rank of years, and said that all of them will praise Hashem, the honoured and the slighted alike, the small and the great alike.

Radak on Tehillim 148:11

“The honoured and the slighted alike, the small and the great alike.” Every rank is summoned. None is exempt, and none is first in praise because it is first in power.

> אבל התחתונים אין בהם נשגב כי אין בגדולתם עמידה וקיום לפיכך לא יתגאו מלכי ארץ שרים ושופטי ארץ בגדולתם כי במעט זמן תשוב ותכלה גדולתם המשגב לה' לבדו

But the lower beings have nothing exalted about them, for there is no standing and no permanence in their greatness. Therefore let the kings of the earth, the princes and the judges of the earth not grow proud in their greatness, for in a short time their greatness returns and is spent. Exaltedness belongs to Hashem alone.

Radak on Tehillim 148:13

Then comes the line the sheet sets beside the swearing-in. The kings and princes and judges of the earth, Radak says, should not grow proud in their greatness, “for in a short time their greatness returns and is spent.” *Hamisgav laShem levado*: exaltedness belongs to Hashem alone.

> יהללו את שם ה' כי נשגב שמו לבדו - שלא יכלה כאשר יכלו כל אלה ויאבדו הפרטים

“Let them praise the name of Hashem, for His name alone is exalted”: for it will not come to an end as all these come to an end, and the individual things perish.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 148:13

Ibn Ezra says the same thing about the name. “His name alone is exalted,” because it will not come to an end as all these come to an end.

The ceremony in the plenum

On the afternoon of Tuesday 10 November 2026 the 26th Knesset was sworn in. Israel National News reported that President Isaac Herzog arrived at the Knesset plaza with a motorcycle escort and mounted horsemen and was welcomed by Speaker Amir Ohana; that the President reviewed the honour guard and laid a wreath at the memorials to fallen soldiers and victims of terror; and that Ohana then escorted him into the building. The Jerusalem Post described the order of the session: the President opens with three strikes of the gavel, invites the Speaker to take the oath, and hands over the chair; then each of the 120 members is called by name and rises to say, *ani mitchayev*, “I pledge.”

In his remarks, as reported by Israel National News, the President said: “A state is not only tested in times of heroism, it is tested no less on a mundane day, in routine. There is immense greatness in heroism. But there is also greatness in the ability to build a daily life, in small and routine tasks.”

It is a ceremony of kings and princes and judges in the language of the psalm: the head of state, the Speaker, the legislators, and the families watching from the galleries. It is right that it is solemn. Psalm 148 does not object to the ceremony. It adds a line beneath it. The summons to the kings of the earth is a summons to praise, and it does not confer permanence. The ceremony marks the beginning of a term. The term will end, as every term ends. The name that is exalted alone does not.

Elders with youths

> זקנים עם נערים. שהזקנים ילמדום היאך יהללו ה' זהו שאמר עם, כי אין בנערים לבדו דעת להלל לפיכך אמר שהזקנים יהיו עם הנערים וילמדום
>
> *“Elders with youths”: that the elders will teach them how to praise Hashem. That is why he said “with,” for the youths alone do not have the understanding to praise; so he said that the elders will be with the youths and will teach them.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 148:12

Radak’s comment on “elders with youths” is a small treasure. The elders are with the youths in order to teach them how to praise, “for the youths alone do not have the understanding.” Praise is learned. It is passed down.

The 26th Knesset has 46 members serving for the first time, by the count in the Times of Israel live blog and in Ynet; other counts, including one in the Times of Israel itself, give 47. Ynet also reported a record 33 women. Whatever the exact number, a large share of

the house is new. The psalm's pairing of elders and youths is a good wish for any such body: that the experienced teach, and that the new are willing to learn.

The smaller arenas

The sheet makes a point that is easy to skip. Psalm 148 summons the cosmos, and the kings of the earth, and also *the young men and the maidens*. It does not leave out the ordinary person. Topic 21 speaks of "Pittsburgh sports or Jerusalem family routines as secondary arenas of bitachon," and topic 48 of "household routines in Jerusalem and daily study while negotiations are unresolved."

That may sound like a long way from the angels. It is not. The psalm's order runs from the highest to the lowest, and it includes everything in between. A family keeping its Shabbos table during a war is inside the summons. So is a father learning with his son before school. So, for that matter, is a man in Jerusalem with Pittsburgh roots who still checks the Sunday score and says *gam zu letovah* when it goes the wrong way. Bitachon is practised in small places first. If it is not there, it will not be found in the large ones.

The horn of His people

וירם קרן לעמו תהלה לכל־חסידיו לבני ישראל עם קרבו הללו-[ה']

> *He has raised up a horn for His people, praise for all His devoted ones, for the children of Israel, the people close to Him. Halleluyah.*
> Tehillim 148:14

The psalm ends with Israel, "the people close to Him." After the whole of creation has been summoned, the last line comes home. Radak reads it as the redemption, when the nations will see that everything stands by Hashem's power. For now, it is enough to say it as the closing line of a roll call: everything praises, and Israel is near.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 148

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 הללו-[ה'] הללו את־ה' מן־השמים הללוהו במרומים

Hallelujah.
Praise the L-RD from the heavens;
praise Him on high.

2 הללוהו כל־מלאכיו הללוהו כל־צבאו

Praise Him, all His angels,
praise Him, all His hosts.

3 הללוהו שמש וירח הללוהו כל־כוכבי אור

Praise Him, sun and moon,
praise Him, all bright stars.

4 הללוהו שמי השמים והמים אשר מעל השמים

Praise Him, highest heavens,
and you waters that are above the heavens.

5 יהללו את־שם ה' כי הוא צוה ונבראו

Let them praise the name of the L-RD,
for it was He who commanded that they be created.

6 ויעמידם לעד לעולם חק־נתן ולא יעבור

He made them endure forever,
establishing an order that shall never change.

7 הללו את־ה' מן־הארץ תנינים וכל־תהמות

Praise the L-RD, O you who are on earth,
all sea monsters and ocean depths,

8 אש וברד שלג וקיטור רוח סערה עשה דברו

fire and hail, snow and smoke,
storm wind that executes His command,

9 ההרים וכל־גבעות עץ פרי וכל־ארזים

all mountains and hills,
all fruit trees and cedars,

10 החיה וכל־בהמה רמש וצפור כנף

all wild and tamed beasts,
creeping things and winged birds,

11 מלכי־ארץ וכל־לאמים שרים וכל־שפטי ארץ

all kings and peoples of the earth,
all princes of the earth and its judges,

12 בחורים וגם־בתולות זקנים עם־נערים

youths and maidens alike,
old and young together.

13 יהללו את־שם ה' כי־נשגב שמו לבדו הודו על־ארץ ושמים

Let them praise the name of the L-RD,
for His name, His alone, is sublime;
His splendor covers heaven and earth.

14 וירם קרן לעמו תהלה לכל־חסידיו לבני ישראל עם קרבו הללו-[ה']

He has exalted the horn of His people
for the glory of all His faithful ones,
Israel, the people close to Him.
Hallelujah.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Radak says “praise” in this psalm is not a command but a description of what is fitting. How does that change the way you say it?
2. The stormy wind is called a messenger. Which human messengers in the present crisis deserve our gratitude, even if we cannot see the outcome of their work?
3. Radak warns the kings and judges of the earth not to grow proud, because their greatness is short. How might a new member of the Knesset take that warning to heart on the day of the oath?
4. What are the “smaller arenas” of your own week, and how is bitachon practised there?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 148:1–2: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.148.1-2
- Radak on Tehillim 148:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.148.1.2
- Tehillim 148:5–6: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.148.5-6
- Rashi on Tehillim 148:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.148.6.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 148:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.148.6.2
- Tehillim 148:7–8: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.148.7-8
- Rashi on Tehillim 148:8: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.148.8.4
- Radak on Tehillim 148:8: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.148.8.4
- Tehillim 148:11–13: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.148.11-13
- Radak on Tehillim 148:11: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.148.11.1
- Radak on Tehillim 148:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.148.13.1

- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 148:13: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.148.13.1
- Radak on Tehillim 148:12: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.148.12.2
- Tehillim 148:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.148.14

CHAPTER 7

A New Song: The Two-Edged Sword of Psalm 149

Tehillim 149 with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David

Topics from the sheet: 8. Psalm 149:2 local resilience in the hills of Jerusalem; 33. Psalm 149:4 Hashem takes pleasure in His people; posture of ordinary households; 34. Two-edged sword of Psalm 149:6 and speech/intention

A new song

Tehillim 149 begins with a phrase that appears several times in the book, *shiru laShem shir chadash*, sing to Hashem a new song. Radak explains what is new about it.

> הללו-[ה'] שירו לה' שיר חדש תהלתו בקהל חסידים ישמח ישראל בעשיו בני־ציון יגילו במלכם
>
> *Halleluyah. Sing to Hashem a new song, His praise in the assembly of the devoted. Let Israel rejoice in its Maker; let the children of Zion delight in their King.*
>
> Tehillim 149:1–2

> שירו לה' שיר חדש. כלומר לא יהיה להם די בשירים האלה הכתובים אלא הם יחדשו לו שיר
>
> *"Sing to Hashem a new song": that is, these written songs will not be enough for them; they will make a new song for Him.*
>
> Radak on Tehillim 149:1

The songs already written will not be enough. The people will make a new one. That is a striking thing to find near the end of the Psalter. The book is almost complete, and its next-to-last psalm says that the book is not the limit of praise.

Let the children of Zion delight in their King

The second verse names two joys. Israel rejoices *be'osav*, in its Maker, and the children of Zion delight *bemalkam*, in their King. Metzudas David reads *be'osav* as "by the help of the One who made him great." The joy is in the source of greatness, not in the greatness itself.

The sheet pairs this verse with "local resilience in the hills of Jerusalem" and "the source of ordinary courage." That is a fair reading. The children of Zion are not described here as warriors or politicians. They are described as people who rejoice in

their King. Ordinary courage begins there. A person who knows Whose he is can face a hard winter without pretending that it is easy.

Hashem takes pleasure in His people

כי־רוצה ה' בעמו יפאר ענוים בישועה

For Hashem takes pleasure in His people; He adorns the humble with salvation.
Tehillim 149:4

כי. להם נאוה להלל יותר מכל עם בישועה שהושיעם כי בהם רצה מכל עם מפני שהם ענוים מכל עם

"For": it is fitting for them to praise more than any people, for the salvation with which He saved them; for He took pleasure in them because they are humbler than any people.
Radak on Tehillim 149:4

Radak explains why praise is fitting for Israel more than for any people: for the salvation with which He saved them, and because He took pleasure in them, "for they are humbler than any people." The pleasure is not in numbers or in strength. It is in humility.

The sheet sets this verse beside "the posture appropriate for ordinary households on the day of the inaugural session," and adds a line worth repeating: it "does not depend on the arithmetic of seats." Hashem's pleasure in His people was the same on the morning of 10 November as it was the day before the election and as it will be the day a government is formed. No coalition adds to it. No deadlock subtracts from it.

Upon their beds

יעלזו חסידים בכבוד ירננו על־משכבותם רוממות [ה'] בגרונם וחרב פיפיות בידם

Let the devoted exult in glory; let them sing for joy upon their beds. Exaltations of G-d are in their throat, and a two-edged sword in their hand.
Tehillim 149:5–6

על משכבותם. על מנוחתם כי על המשכב ינוח האדם ור"ל ירננו לה' כשיהיו בארצם במנוחה

"Upon their beds": upon their rest, for a person rests upon his bed. That is, they will sing for joy to Hashem when they are in their land at rest.
Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:5

וטעם ירננו על משכבותם – בהתבודדם בלילה

And the sense of "let them sing for joy upon their beds": when they are alone at night.
Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 149:5

Two readings of "upon their beds." Metzudas David: when they are at rest in their land. Ibn Ezra: when they are alone at night. Both are images of quiet. The verse that follows is the loudest in the psalm, but it begins in a bedroom.

The two-edged sword

The sixth verse is the hardest, and the sheet rightly gives it its own topic. *Romemos Kel bigronam, vecherev pifiyos beyadam*: exaltations of G-d in their throat, and a two-edged sword in their hand.

Read plainly, it describes the war of the end of days: praise in the mouth and a sword in the hand. Radak reads it that way.

> רוממות [ה']. כשיבואו למלחמה עם גוג מגוג כך ירוממו [ה'] כי שהוציאם מן הגלות, והתפלה תהיה בפיהם וחרב בידם

> *"Exaltations of G-d": when they come to war with Gog and Magog, so will they exalt G-d, who brought them out of exile; and prayer will be in their mouth and a sword in their hand.*
> Radak on Tehillim 149:6

But Rashi reads the verse differently.

> רוממות [ה'] בגרונם. והם לחרב פיפיות בידם:

> *"Exaltations of G-d in their throat": and they are, for them, a two-edged sword in their hand.*
> Rashi on Tehillim 149:6

For Rashi, the exaltations of G-d *are* the two-edged sword. The praise in the throat is the weapon in the hand. Metzudas David spells it out.

> בגרונם יספרו רוממות [ה'] וזה תהיה לחרב פיפיות בידם ר"ל ע"ז תגברו על האויב כאלו אחזו בידם חרב בעלת שתי פיות חדודה משתי הצדדים

> *In their throat they will tell the exaltations of G-d, and this will be a two-edged sword in their hand. That is, through this you will prevail over the enemy as though they held in their hand a sword with two mouths, sharp on both sides.*
> Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:6

"Through this you will prevail over the enemy as though they held in their hand a sword with two mouths." The word *pifiyos*, literally "mouths," is the bridge. A sword has edges called mouths, and a mouth that praises is a sword.

Words that cut both ways

The sheet connects this verse to Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3, which is the subject of chapter 11. The link is the question of speech and intention. A two-edged sword cuts in two directions. Speech does the same. Words of praise that come from the heart rise.

Words that are spoken without intention, or with the wrong intention, can turn back on the speaker.

That is the sense of topic 34: “the distinction between words merely spoken and words directed toward Hashem.” It is also, quietly, a warning about public speech in a season like this one. Every day of November 2026 brings statements from leaders in Jerusalem, Washington, Tehran and the Gulf. Some are threats, some are offers, some are boasts, some are prayers. We cannot know the intentions behind them, and the laws of speech forbid us to assign intentions we cannot know. But we can know our own. When we speak about the news, at the Shabbos table or online, our words are also a two-edged sword. They can build or they can cut.

The judgment that is written

> לעשות בהם משפט כתוב הדר הוא לכל־חסידיו הללו־[ה']

To carry out upon them the judgment that is written; it is a splendour for all His devoted ones. Halleluyah.

Tehillim 149:9

> ואם תאמר עדין לא נולד יחזקאל כשאמר דוד זאת? נתנבא דוד על קץ הגאלה, וכשיבא הקץ, כבר כתוב הוא המשפט זה ימים רבים

And if you ask: Yechezkel was not yet born when David said this? David prophesied about the end of the redemption; and when the end comes, this judgment will already have been written for many days.

Rashi on Tehillim 149:9

The psalm ends with *mishpat kasuv*, the judgment that is written. Rashi asks how David could speak of a judgment “written” by Yechezkel, who was not yet born. His answer: David prophesied about the end of days, and by the time the end comes, the judgment will long since have been written.

That answer has a lesson about patience. Some judgments are written long before they are carried out. A reader who wants the psalm’s justice to arrive this week will be frustrated. The psalm itself says the judgment is in writing, not that it is already done. “It is a splendour for all His devoted ones,” and they can wait for it.

Ordinary courage in the hills of Jerusalem

The phrase in topic 8, “local resilience in the hills of Jerusalem,” is not in the psalm, but it is in the spirit of it. The children of Zion who rejoice in their King are the same people who drive to work through the hills, send their children to school, and say Hallel on Rosh Chodesh. Their courage is quiet: the courage of continuing. Psalm 149 calls it singing a new song.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 149

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 הללו-[ה'] שירו לה' שיר חדש תהלתו בקהל חסידים

Hallelujah.
Sing to the L-RD a new song,
His praises in the congregation of the faithful.

2 ישמח ישראל בעשיו בני־ציון יגילו במלכם

Let Israel rejoice in its maker;
let the children of Zion exult in their king.

3 יהללו שמו במחול בתף וכנור יזמרו־לו

Let them praise His name in dance;
with timbrel and lyre let them chant His praises.

4 כי־רוצה ה' בעמו יפאר ענוים בישועה

For the L-RD delights in His people;
He adorns the lowly with victory.

5 יעלזו חסידים בכבוד ירננו על־משכבותם

Let the faithful exult in glory;
let them shout for joy upon their couches,

6 רוממות [ה'] בגרונם וחרב פיפיות בידם

with paeans to G-d in their throats
and two-edged swords in their hands,

7 לעשות נקמה בגוים תוכחות בלאמים

to impose retribution upon the nations,
punishment upon the peoples,

8 לאסר מלכיהם בזקים ונכבדיהם בכבלי ברזל

binding their kings with shackles,
their nobles with chains of iron,

9 לעשות בהם משפט כתוב הדר הוא לכל־חסידיו הללו־[ה']

executing the doom decreed against them.
This is the glory of all His faithful.
Hallelujah.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Radak says the written songs will not be enough and a new song will be made. What would a new song of praise sound like in our generation?
2. Rashi reads praise itself as the two-edged sword; Radak reads a real sword alongside prayer. What does each reading teach that the other does not?
3. How do our own words about the news "cut both ways"? Give an example from your week, without naming anyone you might wrong.
4. "The judgment that is written" may be carried out long after it is written. How does that help us read events we do not understand?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tehillim 149:1–2: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.149.1-2
- Radak on Tehillim 149:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.149.1.2
- Tehillim 149:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.149.4
- Radak on Tehillim 149:4: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.149.4.1
- Tehillim 149:5–6: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.149.5-6
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.149.5.2
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 149:5: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.149.5.2
- Radak on Tehillim 149:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.149.6.1
- Rashi on Tehillim 149:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.149.6.1
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.149.6.1
- Tehillim 149:9: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.149.9
- Rashi on Tehillim 149:9: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.149.9.1

CHAPTER 8

Let Every Soul Praise: Psalm 150 and Tehillim with a Minyan

Tehillim 150 with Radak, Ibn Ezra and Metzudas David, Shabbos 118b, and the Hayom Yom for 30 Cheshvan

Topics from the sheet: 9. Final Hallel of Psalm 150 and Hayom Yom merit of communal Tehillim; 22. Tehillim cycle for the 30th and merit of communal recitation; 25. Concluding doxology of the Psalter as horizon; 35. Psalm 150:6 let every soul praise and Hayom Yom minyan; 49. Explicit cycle of Tehillim 145–150 and Hayom Yom communal merit; 50. Concluding doxology as horizon after arithmetic and status are noted

Thirteen praises

The Psalter ends with a psalm of six verses that does almost nothing but repeat a single word. *Halleluhu*, praise Him, appears ten times, and the psalm opens and closes with *Halleluyah*. Radak counts them and finds a meaning in the number.

זה המזמור יש בו שלשה עשר הלולים רמז לשלש עשרה מדות

This psalm has in it thirteen praises, an allusion to the thirteen attributes [of mercy].
Radak on Tehillim 150:1

Thirteen praises, against the thirteen attributes of mercy. The last psalm of the book is a song of mercy, set out in a form that anyone can count.

Radak reads the first verse as a ladder: “in His sanctuary” is the world of the angels, and “in the firmament of His strength” is the highest sphere that surrounds everything, in which His strength is seen. Then he says: “Praise Him” is said to Israel. The psalm begins above and comes down to us.

According to His abundant greatness

הללוהו בגבורתיו הללוהו כרב גדלו

Praise Him for His mighty acts; praise Him according to His abundant greatness.
Tehillim 150:2

הללוהו כרוב גדלו - הטעם הללוהו הרבה, כאשר גדולתו רבה

"Praise Him according to His abundant greatness": the meaning is, praise Him much, as His greatness is much.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:2

Ibn Ezra's comment is two lines long and very deep. Praise Him much, because His greatness is much. The measure of the praise is set by its object, not by the one praising. That is a challenge. Most of us praise according to our own capacity, or our mood, or the time we have before work. The verse asks for praise according to His greatness, which has no end.

Radak adds a historical note to the same verse: He "was made great and sanctified among the nations" through Israel's redemption. The greatness is seen in what He does for His people.

Shofar, harp and cymbal

הללוהו בתקע שופר הללוהו בנבל וכנור הללוהו בתף ומחול הללוהו במנים ועגב הללוהו בצלצלי־שמע הללוהו בצלצלי תרועה

Praise Him with the blast of the shofar; praise Him with harp and lyre. Praise Him with drum and dance; praise Him with strings and flute. Praise Him with resounding cymbals; praise Him with clanging cymbals.

Tehillim 150:3–5

The middle of the psalm is an orchestra. Shofar, harp, lyre, drum, dance, strings, flute, two kinds of cymbal. Radak admits that some of these instruments "are not known to us." That honesty is worth noticing. We say the names every morning, and we do not know exactly what all of them sounded like.

What we do know is that the list includes everything: wind, string and percussion, the solo instrument and the dance. Every kind of sound is drafted into praise.

Let every soul praise

כל הנשמה תהלל [ה'] הללו-[ה']

Let every soul praise Hashem. Halleluyah.

Tehillim 150:6

The last verse widens the circle to its limit. *Kol haneshamah*, every soul, everything that breathes.

ועל כל ההילולים הוא הילול הנשמה והוא התבונן במעשה [ה'] יתברך ובידיעה כפי כח הנשמה בעודה בגוף

And above all the praises is the praise of the soul, which is contemplation of the works of G-d, may He be blessed, and knowledge according to the power of the soul while it is still in the body.

Radak on Tehillim 150:6

Radak says that above all the instruments is the praise of the soul, and he defines it: contemplation of the works of G-d, and knowledge "according to the power of the soul while it is still in the body." The highest praise is understanding.

ואמר כל מי שיש בו נשמה ונפש משכלת תהלל את [ה'], נשלם ספר תהלים

And he said: everyone who has in him a soul and an understanding spirit, let him praise Hashem. The book of Tehillim is complete.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 150:6

Metzudas David reads it simply: everyone who has a soul and an understanding spirit. And then he adds three words that end his commentary on the whole book: *nishlam sefer Tehillim*, the book of Tehillim is complete.

ואברהם בנו מאיר כללם: ולא תמו תהלות [ה'] לעולם, ומי הוא זה אשר החל וכלם

And Avraham son of Meir [Ibn Ezra himself] summed them up: the praises of G-d will never be finished; and who is the one who began them and completed them?

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:6

Ibn Ezra closes in the first person. "Avraham son of Meir" says the praises of G-d will never be finished, and asks: who is the one who began them and completed them? The book is complete, but the praise is not.

The sheet calls this verse "inclusive." It is the most inclusive line in the Psalter. It does not say every Jew, or every righteous person, or every member of a congregation. It says every soul.

Saying the whole of Hallel

On the 30th of the month, the monthly cycle of Tehillim ends with these six psalms, 145 to 150. They are the same psalms said every morning in Pesukei deZimra. The Gemara in Shabbos speaks about them.

> אמר רבי יוסי: יהא חלקי מגומרי הלל בכל יום. איני?! והאמר מר: הקורא הלל בכל יום הרי זה מחרף ומגדף! כי קאמרינן — בפסוקי דזמרא

Rabbi Yosei said: May my portion be with those who complete Hallel every day. Is that so? But the Master said: one who reads Hallel every day is like one who reviles and blasphemes! When we say this, it refers to the Verses of Song [Pesukei deZimra].

Shabbos 118b

Rabbi Yosei wished his portion to be with those who complete Hallel every day. The Gemara objects that saying the festival Hallel every day is improper, and answers that Rabbi Yosei meant Pesukei deZimra: these psalms. The daily recitation is a regular portion, not a holiday performance.

So on 30 Cheshvan, a person who says the monthly cycle and davens Shacharis says these psalms twice. The cycle is fixed. It does not move because of the news. It happened to fall, this year, on the day of the swearing-in and on Rosh Chodesh Kislev, and the psalms were waiting.

The merit of saying Tehillim together

The Hayom Yom shown on Chabad.org for Tuesday 30 Cheshvan 5787 is the entry for Shabbos 29 Cheshvan of 5704 (1943). It opens with the blessing of the new month.

> מברכים ר"ח כסלו. אמירת כל התהילים בהשכמה. יום התוועדות.

Bless Rosh Chodesh Kislev. Say the entire Tehillim in the early morning. Day of farbrengen.

Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704)

> עבודה הקדושה באמירת תהלים בצבור, אין די באר גודל הזכות של המשתתפים בזה, וגודל הנחת רוח של מעלה כמבואר בספרי קודש

We cannot adequately describe the great merit of those who participate in the sacred avoda of saying Tehillim with a minyan, and the great pleasure this avoda causes On High, as discussed in sacred texts.

Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704), as read on Chabad.org for 30 Cheshvan 5787

> ואשריכם ישראל, ובגלל זאת תתברכו אתם נשיכם בניכם ובנותיכם

How fortunate are you Israel, and for this may you all be blessed with proper health and with super-abundant livelihood — you, your wives, your sons and your daughters.

Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704)

The entry was compiled and arranged by the Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, in 5703 (1943), from the talks and letters of his father-in-law, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn; the English is Kehot's. The Rebbe Rayatz speaks of "the sacred avoda of saying Tehillim with a minyan," and he does not try to describe its

merit. He says it cannot be described. He blesses those who take part with health and livelihood, “you, your wives, your sons and your daughters,” and asks that in their merit the whole community be helped.

The sheet connects this to topics 22, 35 and 49: “public gatherings or study groups on the day of swearing-in” and “the public character of the ceremony.” The connection is not a comparison of two ceremonies. The swearing-in is a civic act, rightly public. Tehillim with a minyan is a different kind of public act. It does not confer authority on anyone. It asks for help for everyone.

A horizon after the arithmetic

Topics 25 and 50 call Psalm 150 a “horizon.” The word fits. By the end of this booklet we will have noted many numbers: 120 seats, 67 recommendations, 46 or 47 new members, 28 days for a mandate, a few hundred transits through a strait in a week. Those numbers matter, and they are recorded here with care.

Psalm 150 has no numbers in it at all, except the ones Radak finds by counting the praises. It has no seats, no deadlines and no shipping lanes. It sets the horizon against which all the numbers are read. On the morning of 10 November 2026, before any of the day’s events, the cycle of Tehillim had already brought its readers to the last line of the book: let every soul praise Hashem.

Topic 25 asks for Psalm 150 as a “measure” for the Hormuz negotiations and the consultations of the day. The measure is not a prediction. It does not tell us what will happen in the Strait or in the Knesset. It tells us where to look while we wait.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Tehillim 150

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

1 הללו-[ה'] הללו-[ה'] בקדשו הללוהו ברקיע עזו

Hallelujah.
Praise G-d in His sanctuary;
praise Him in the sky, His stronghold.

2 הללוהו בגבורתיו הללוהו כרב גדלו

Praise Him for His mighty acts;
praise Him for His exceeding greatness.

3 הַלְלוּהוּ בְּתֵקַע שׁוֹפָר הַלְלוּהוּ בְּנֵבֶל וְכִנּוֹר

Praise Him with blasts of the horn;
praise Him with harp and lyre.

4 הַלְלוּהוּ בְתֹף וּמָחוֹל הַלְלוּהוּ בְּמִנִּים וְעֻגָב

Praise Him with timbrel and dance;
praise Him with lute and pipe.

5 הַלְלוּהוּ בְצִלְצְלֵי־שָׁמַע הַלְלוּהוּ בְּצִלְצְלֵי תְרוּעָה

Praise Him with resounding cymbals;
praise Him with loud-clashing cymbals.

6 כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל [ה'] הַלְלוּ-[ה']

Let all that breathes praise the L-RD.
Hallelujah.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Radak counts thirteen praises and links them to the thirteen attributes of mercy. Why might the Psalter end with mercy rather than judgment?
2. Ibn Ezra says to praise Hashem “much, as His greatness is much.” What would that look like on an ordinary weekday?
3. Radak says the highest praise is the soul’s understanding. How does learning become a form of praise?
4. The Hayom Yom says the merit of Tehillim with a minyan cannot be described. Have you seen something of that merit in your own community?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Radak on Tehillim 150:1: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.150.1.1
- Tehillim 150:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.150.2
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.150.2.2
- Tehillim 150:3–5: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.150.3-5
- Tehillim 150:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.150.6
- Radak on Tehillim 150:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.150.6.2
- Metzudas David on Tehillim 150:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.150.6.1
- Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:6: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.150.6.1
- Shabbos 118b: https://www.sefaria.org/Shabbat.118b.4
- Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704): https://www.chabad.org/dailystudy/hayomyom.asp?tdate=11/10/2026

• Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704), as read on Chabad.org for 30 Cheshvan 5787: https://www.chabad.org/dailystudy/hayomyom.asp?tdate=11/10/2026

CHAPTER 9

The Stopped Wells: Growth, Envy and the Stated Reason

Bereishis 26:12–16 with Rashi, Ramban, Radak and Sforno

Topics from the sheet: 11. Rashi on Philistines stopping wells for security reasons; 17. Philistine envy of Isaac's growth and preference for status quo; 39. Rashi's security reason and contemporary transit permits; 40. Isaac's growth and envy set beside economic disruption preference

A hundredfold in a hard year

The Chumash portion for Tuesday of Toldos, the third aliyah, runs from Bereishis 26:13 to 26:22. It is set just after Yitzchak's great harvest.

> ויזרע יצחק בארץ ההוא וימצא בשנה ההוא מאה שערים ויברכהו ה'
>
> *Yitzchak sowed in that land, and in that year he found a hundredfold; and Hashem blessed him.*
> Bereishis 26:12

> בארץ ההיא בשנה ההיא. שניהם למה? לומר, שהארץ קשה והשנה קשה
>
> *"In that land, in that year": why both? To say that the land was hard and the year was hard.*
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:12 (citing Bereishis Rabbah)

> מאה שערים. שאמדוה כמה ראויה לעשות, ועשתה על אחת שאמדוה מאה. ורבותינו אמרו אמד זה למעשרות היה
>
> *"A hundredfold": they estimated how much it ought to yield, and it yielded a hundred for each one they estimated. And our Rabbis said: this estimate was for tithes.*
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:12

Rashi, following the Midrash, reads every phrase as a surprise. "In that land, in that year": the land was hard and the year was hard, and still he found a hundredfold. The hundredfold is measured against an estimate, and the Sages say the estimate was made for tithes. Yitzchak was counting in order to give. (That detail returns in chapter 12, where the Gemara of the day is also about counting for tithes.)

The man grew great

> ויגדל האיש וילך הלוך וגדל עד כי־גדל מאד ויהי־לו מקנה־צאן ומקנה בקר ועבדה רבה ויקנאו אתו פלשתים

The man grew great, and kept growing greater, until he was very great. He had possessions of flocks and possessions of herds and a large household; and the Pelishtim envied him.

Bereishis 26:13–14

> כי גדל מאוד. שהיו אומרים זבל פרדותיו של יצחק ולא כספו וזהבו של אבימלך

"Until he was very great": for people would say, "Rather the dung of Yitzchak's mules than the silver and gold of Avimelech."

Rashi on Bereishis 26:13 (citing Bereishis Rabbah)

The verse uses the root *gadal* three times: he grew great, kept growing greater, until he was very great. Rashi gives the Midrash's proverb: people said, "Rather the dung of Yitzchak's mules than the silver and gold of Avimelech." Yitzchak's waste was worth more than the king's treasury.

> ויזכיר הכתוב זה ולא יזכיר כסף וזהב כאשר נאמר באברהם (בראשית י"ג:ב'), בעבור כי גדלתו אשר נתגדל בה בארץ פלשתים במקנה ובעבדה היתה, ויקנאו אותו פלשתים בענין ההוא. וזה טעם "כי עצמת ממנו מאד", אמר לו גם לי שאני המלך אין בביתי מקנה ועבדה כמוך, וחרפה היא לנו להיות ביתך גדול מבית המלך

Scripture mentions this, and does not mention silver and gold as it said of Avraham, because the greatness he gained in the land of the Pelishtim was in livestock and in a household, and the Pelishtim envied him in that matter. And that is the sense of "for you have become much mightier than we": he said to him, even I, who am the king, have no livestock and household in my house like yours, and it is a disgrace to us that your house is greater than the king's house.

Ramban on Bereishis 26:14

Ramban notices what the Torah lists and what it leaves out. Of Avraham it said silver and gold. Of Yitzchak it says flocks, herds and a large household. That was the kind of greatness the Pelishtim could see every day, and it was the kind they envied. When Avimelech says, "You have become much mightier than we," Ramban hears the king himself: "Even I, who am the king, have no livestock and household like yours, and it is a disgrace to us that your house is greater than the king's house."

> ויקנאו אתו פלשתים. שבשדותיהם קרה אז הפך זה, שזרעו הרבה והביאו מעט

"And the Pelishtim envied him": because in their fields the opposite happened at that time: they sowed much and brought in little.

Sforno on Bereishis 26:14

Sforno adds an agricultural detail. In the same year the Pelishtim had the opposite experience: they sowed much and brought in little. Their envy was not abstract. It grew from their own empty fields, next to his full ones.

The stopped wells

וכל־הבארת אשר חפרו עבדי אביו בימי אברהם אביו סתמום פלשתים וימלאום עפר

And all the wells that his father's servants had dug in the days of Avraham his father, the Pelishtim stopped up and filled with earth.

Bereishis 26:15

The Pelishtim did not attack Yitzchak. They stopped up the wells his father's servants had dug, and filled them with earth. Why? The commentators give three answers, and each is worth hearing.

סתמום פלשתים. מפני שאמרו תקלה הם לנו מפני הגיסות הבאות עלינו

"The Pelishtim stopped them up": because they said, "They are a hazard to us, because of the raiding troops that come against us."

Rashi on Bereishis 26:15

Rashi: they said the wells were a hazard, because of the raiding troops that came against them. An open well in the land is a supply point for any invader. Stopping it is a security measure.

ולמה סתמום? אמרו: שמא היום או מחר יגדל כח יצחק ויכלתו כאביו ויקחם, לפיכך סתמום, כי אמרו: גם לו גם לנו לא יהיה

And why did they stop them up? They said: perhaps today or tomorrow Yitzchak's strength and ability will grow like his father's, and he will take them. Therefore they stopped them up, for they said: neither for him nor for us shall it be.

Radak on Bereishis 26:15

Radak: they feared that one day Yitzchak would grow as strong as his father and take the wells. So they decided: "Neither for him nor for us shall it be." Better that no one have the water than that a rival have it.

סתמום פלשתים. כאשר יראו מצות אבימלך לבלתי הזיק ליצחק, סתמו הבארות בשנאת קנאתם

"The Pelishtim stopped them up": when they saw the command of Avimelech not to harm Yitzchak, they stopped up the wells in the hatred of their envy.

Sforno on Bereishis 26:15

Sforno: Avimelech had commanded that no one harm Yitzchak. So the Pelishtim stopped the wells instead, "in the hatred of their envy."

> ולא לשנאתו רק בימי אברהם לא רצו לסתמם מפני כבודו, כי אמרו אולי ישוב לשבת בארץ

And not out of hatred of him; only, in the days of Avraham they did not want to stop them up because of his honour, for they said, perhaps he will come back to live in the land.

Ramban on Bereishis 26:17

Ramban adds a point about timing. While Avraham lived they did not touch the wells, out of respect for him, in case he came back. Only after his death did they stop them, and not out of hatred.

Four commentators, four readings. Rashi gives the reason they said aloud: security. Radak gives a strategic fear. Sforno gives envy. Ramban says it was not hatred. The Torah itself states only the act.

Go away from us

> ויאמר אבימלך אל־יצחק לך מעמנו כי־עצמת ממנו מאד

And Avimelech said to Yitzchak: "Go away from us, for you have become much mightier than we."

Bereishis 26:16

> כי עצמת ממנו. ותוכל בעשרך להתקומם עלינו

"For you have become much mightier than we": and with your wealth you could rise up against us.

Sforno on Bereishis 26:16

Avimelech asks Yitzchak to leave, and Sforno reads the request as fear: with your wealth you could rise up against us. Yitzchak goes, without argument, and camps in the valley.

Stated reasons and examined motives

The sheet places these verses beside the Strait of Hormuz. Topic 11 sets Rashi's security reason beside "the claim that control of Hormuz is required for security." Topic 39 sets it beside "the practice of requiring transit permits or coordination for passage."

The facts are these. Iran has set up a body it calls the Persian Gulf Strait Authority. Its published terms say that no vessel may pass the Strait without a permit, that a request must be filed at least 48 hours ahead, that each permit covers one transit and is valid for at most five days, and that ships must keep to a set route near Larak Island. The Indian Express, quoting the authority's notice, gives its stated reason: "Due to the presence of mine-affected areas and the necessity of ensuring safe passage and preventing collisions, coordination of the designated route and scheduled passage time for each vessel prior to moving toward the strait is mandatory." Iran's foreign ministry spokesman, Esmaeil Baghaei, said on 9 November that ships passing through the Strait

must coordinate with the relevant Iranian authorities (as reported by CGTN). Al Jazeera reported on 6 November that an Iranian lawmaker said ships from India, China, Iraq and Qatar were exempted from the restrictions.

The stated reason is security, as it was in Rashi's reading. The Torah does not ask us to decide whether the Pelishtim meant it. It records four readings among the commentators and passes judgment on none of the people involved. That is the posture this booklet takes as well. We record the stated reason. We do not assign motives to any government or person we cannot see into.

Envy and the status quo

Topics 17 and 40 ask a harder question. They set the Pelishtim's envy beside a "reported regional preference for the status quo rather than escalation," and ask whether economic disruption produced a preference for a restricted equilibrium. The sheet marks both as needing verification.

What can be said from opened sources is this. On 10 November, Reuters, in a report carried by Khaleej Times, quoted President Trump as saying that "Qatar, Saudi Arabia, UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, and others, would prefer the status quo." That is the US president's description of other governments' views. It is not those governments' own statement. The UAE's senior diplomatic adviser, Anwar Gargash, said on 1 November, according to The National, that restoring the Strait to its prewar state was non-negotiable, and on 9 November urged preparing for "a long period of uncertainty."

So the "regional preference for the status quo" is reported, but by one side about others, and at least one of the others has said something quite different in public. This booklet does not treat it as established. And it does not take the next step the sheet hints at, of comparing anyone's preference to the envy of the Pelishtim. The sheet's own guidance says it well: examine motives without assuming identity. Bereishis 26 names envy as one reading of what happened in Gerar. It does not authorise us to name it in Riyadh, Doha or Abu Dhabi.

What Yitzchak did

The most important thing in these verses is what Yitzchak did not do. He did not fight over the stopped wells. He did not argue with Avimelech. He moved to the valley, and then, as the next chapter shows, he started digging again. His answer to stopped wells was a shovel.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Bereishis 26:12–16

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

12 ויזרע יצחק בארץ ההוא וימצא בשנה ההוא מאה שערים ויברכהו ה׳

Isaac sowed in that land and reaped a hundredfold the same year. The L-RD blessed him,

13 ויגדל האיש וילך הלוך וגדל עד כי־גדל מאד

and the man grew richer and richer until he was very wealthy:

14 ויהי־לו מקנה־צאן ומקנה בקר ועבדה רבה ויקנאו אתו פלשתים

he acquired flocks and herds, and a large household, so that the Philistines envied him.

15 וכל־הבארת אשר חפרו עבדי אביו בימי אברהם אביו סתמום פלשתים וימלאום עפר

And the Philistines stopped up all the wells which his father's servants had dug in the days of his father Abraham, filling them with earth.

16 ויאמר אבימלך אל־יצחק לך מעמנו כי־עצמת ממנו מאד

And Abimelech said to Isaac, "Go away from us, for you have become far too big for us."

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Rashi, Radak, Sforno and Ramban each explain the stopping of the wells differently. Which reading seems closest to the plain text, and why?
2. The Torah states the Pelishtim's act but not their motive. Why might it leave the motive to the commentators?
3. Rashi says Yitzchak's hundredfold was estimated for tithes. What does it mean that his abundance was measured by what he could give?
4. When we hear one leader describe what other countries "prefer," how should we weigh it before repeating it?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Bereishis 26:12: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.12
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:12 (citing Bereishis Rabbah): https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.12.3
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:12: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.12.4
- Bereishis 26:13–14: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.13-14
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:13 (citing Bereishis Rabbah): https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.13.1

- Ramban on Bereishis 26:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.14.1
- Sforno on Bereishis 26:14: https://www.sefaria.org/Sforno_on_Genesis.26.14.2
- Bereishis 26:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.15
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.15.1
- Radak on Bereishis 26:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.15.1
- Sforno on Bereishis 26:15: https://www.sefaria.org/Sforno_on_Genesis.26.15.1
- Ramban on Bereishis 26:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.17.1
- Bereishis 26:16: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.16
- Sforno on Bereishis 26:16: https://www.sefaria.org/Sforno_on_Genesis.26.16.1

CHAPTER 10

Esek, Sitnah, Rechovos: Living Water and the Wide Spaces

Bereishis 26:17–22 with Rashi, Ramban, Radak, Ibn Ezra and Sforno, and Yirmiyahu 17:13

Topics from the sheet: 10. Wells of Genesis 26:13–22 (Esek, Sitnah, Rechovot) as pattern; 12. Isaac re-digging Abraham's wells and naming Rechovot; 18. Living water in the valley and practical provision; 19. Move from Sitnah to Rechovot and risk of prolonged contention; 23. Ramban's reading of wells as allusions to Temples; 36. First well Esek and preference for restricted status; 37. Second well Sitnah and risk of hardening into dominion; 38. Third well Rechovot and naming as space Hashem has made; 41. Living water and continuity of desalination and household stores

Digging again

וילך משם יצחק ויחן בנחל־גרר וישב שם וישב יצחק ויחפר את־בארת המים אשר חפרו בימי אברהם אביו ויסתמום פלשתים אחרי מות אברהם ויקרא להן שמות כשמת אשר־קרא להן אביו

So Yitzchak went from there, camped in the valley of Gerar and settled there. Yitzchak dug again the wells of water that had been dug in the days of Avraham his father, which the Pelishtim had stopped up after Avraham's death; and he called them by names like the names his father had called them.

Bereishis 26:17–18

בנחל גרר. רחוק מן העיר

"In the valley of Gerar": far from the city.

Rashi on Bereishis 26:17

Yitzchak leaves Gerar and camps in the valley, which Rashi places "far from the city." He does not start fresh. He goes back to his father's wells, the ones the Pelishtim had stopped, and digs them out again. And he gives them back their old names.

כשמת. להיות בחזקתן הראשונה

"Like the names": so that they would remain in their first established possession.

Radak on Bereishis 26:18

Radak explains why the names matter: so that the wells would remain in their first established possession. Restoring a name is restoring a claim. Yitzchak does not invent a new title to the water. He renews the one his father held.

The sheet calls this “hishtadlut seeking expansion without domination.” Yitzchak works, and works hard. He does not take anything that was not his father’s. Even the naming is modest. He calls the wells what they were called before.

A well of living water

> ויחפרו עבדי־יצחק בנחל וימצאו־שם באר מים חיים ויריבו רעי גרר עם־רעי יצחק לאמר לנו המים ויקרא שם־הבאר עשק כי התעשקו עמו
>
> *Yitzchak’s servants dug in the valley and found there a well of living water. The herdsmen of Gerar quarrelled with Yitzchak’s herdsmen, saying, “The water is ours.” So he called the well Esek, because they had contended with him.*
>
> Bereishis 26:19–20

Then his servants dig in the valley and find something new: *be’er mayim chaim*, a well of living water.

> מים חיים. שהם נובעים תמיד
>
> *“Living water”: water that gushes always.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:19

> וימצאו שם וגו'. אחר שחפרו מצאו מתחת באר חפורה מקדם, והיו נובעים בה מים חיים, זהו שאמר וימצאו באר ולא אמרו "וימצאו מים"
>
> *“And they found there…”: after they dug, they found beneath it a well dug of old, and living water was gushing in it. That is why it says “they found a well,” and does not say “they found water.”*
>
> Radak on Bereishis 26:19

> ועל כן הזכיר הכתוב "וימצאו שם באר מים חיים", לאמר כי היה מקור נובע מים חיים, אין מימיו מן הנחל כאשר אמרו מריביו
>
> *And that is why Scripture mentioned “they found there a well of living water”: to say that it was a gushing spring of living water, whose waters were not from the valley, as his quarrellers claimed.*
>
> Ramban on Bereishis 26:17–19

The three commentators read the phrase closely. Ibn Ezra: living water is water that gushes always. Radak: they found an old well under the place they dug, with living water already flowing in it, which is why the verse says “they found a well” and not “they found water.” Ramban draws the legal point: it was a spring with its own source, not water drawn from the valley as the herdsmen of Gerar claimed.

The phrase *mayim chaim* appears later in Tanach with a deeper meaning.

כי עזבו מקור מים־חיים את־ה'

… for they have forsaken the source of living water, Hashem.
Yirmiyahu 17:13 (closing clause)

Yirmiyahu calls Hashem "the source of living water." The well in the valley is a physical thing, a supply of water for flocks and a household. It is also, in the language of the prophets, a picture of the Source of all supply.

Topics 18 and 41 apply this to "maintaining desalination, energy and household provision under restricted shipping" and to the "practical continuity of desalination plants, energy pipelines and household stores." The sheet's point is simple: ordinary provision is not suspended. Yitzchak's servants kept digging while the dispute went on. Water had to be found for that day's flocks. In a season when one of the world's main shipping lanes is restricted, the same is true of every household and every utility. Provision continues, and the people who keep it going, the engineers, the drivers, the shopkeepers, are doing what Yitzchak's servants did.

Esek

The herdsmen of Gerar quarrelled with Yitzchak's herdsmen: "The water is ours." He called the well Esek.

עשק. ערעור: כי התעשקו עמו. נתעשקו עמו עליה במריבה וערעור

"Esek": a challenge [to ownership]. "Because they had contended with him": they busied themselves with him over it, in quarrel and challenge.
Rashi on Bereishis 26:20

עשק. ידוע בדברי קדמונים, רק במקרא אין לו ריע

"Esek": known from the words of the ancients [the Sages]; only in Scripture it has no companion.
Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:20

התעשקו עמו. השתדלו עם יצחק שיעזב הבאר

"They had contended with him": they pressed Yitzchak to leave the well.
Sforno on Bereishis 26:20

Rashi defines *esek* as a challenge to ownership; they busied themselves with him over it, in quarrel and challenge. Ibn Ezra notes the word appears nowhere else in Scripture and is known from the language of the Sages. Sforno says the herdsmen pressed Yitzchak to leave the well.

ויקרא שם־הבאר עשק. קרא לה שם לפי שהיום או מחר כשיגדל כחו עליהם לא יוכלו לומר רעי גרר כי לנו הבאר בלא שום ערעור, והנה השם יודיע

"He called the name of the well Esek": he gave it a name, so that today or tomorrow, when his strength grew over them, the herdsmen of Gerar would not be able to say "the well is ours" without any challenge; and the name will make it known.

Radak on Bereishis 26:20

Radak sees a purpose in the name. It was a record. Years later, when Yitzchak's strength had grown, no one could say "the well is ours" as though there had never been a challenge. The name itself would testify.

The sheet sets Esek beside a "reported preference among some regional actors for the present restricted status" (topic 36), which the sheet itself marks as needing verification. Chapter 9 sets out what could and could not be confirmed about that report. The sheet's own gloss on the verse is better than any comparison: "contention is named; continuity not required." Yitzchak named the quarrel and did not stay in it.

Sitnah

ויחפרו באר אחרת ויריבו גם־עליה ויקרא שמה שטנה

They dug another well, and they quarrelled over that one too; so he called it Sitnah.

Bereishis 26:21

שטנה. כלומר לשטן הם לנו, כי בכל אשר אנחנו חופרים הם מריבים עמנו

"Sitnah": that is to say, they are an adversary to us, for wherever we dig they quarrel with us.

Radak on Bereishis 26:21

They dug another well, and they quarrelled over that one too. He called it Sitnah, a harder name. Radak: "They are an adversary to us, for wherever we dig they quarrel with us." The first quarrel could be one dispute. The second shows a pattern.

Topic 37 speaks of the "risk that prolonged contention over navigation rights hardens into a standing claim." Topic 19 adds that "prolonged contention over the Strait may yield neither party lasting space." Those are fair readings of the movement from Esek to Sitnah. A first dispute can be settled. A second over the same kind of thing begins to harden. Neither Esek nor Sitnah became Yitzchak's lasting home.

Rechovos

ויעתק משם ויחפר באר אחרת ולא רבו עליה ויקרא שמה רחבות ויאמר כי־עתה הרחיב ה' לנו ופרינו בארץ

He moved on from there and dug another well, and they did not quarrel over it. He called it Rechovos, and said: "For now Hashem has made room for us, and we shall be fruitful in the land."

Bereishis 26:22

ויעתק. העתיק כל חפירתו משם ורחק מעט מגבולם, במקום שלא יוכלו לערער. ולא רבו עליה, כי הדבר היה גלוי ואין במקום ההוא ספק כי מבאר שבע הוא ולא מגרר, לפיכך קרא שמה רחבות להודיע לבאים אחריהם כי לא רבו עליה, על הבאר הזאת

"He moved on": he moved all his digging from there and went a little farther from their border, to a place where they could not challenge. "And they did not quarrel over it," for the matter was plain, and there was no doubt in that place that it was of Be'er Sheva and not of Gerar. Therefore he called it Rechovos, to make known to those who would come after them that they had not quarrelled over it, over this well.

Radak on Bereishis 26:22

ופרינו בארץ. כי אין שטן ומריב, ונפרה ונרבה במקנה

"And we shall be fruitful in the land": for there is no adversary and no quarreller, and we will be fruitful and multiply in livestock.

Radak on Bereishis 26:22

ופרינו בארץ. כתרגומו וניפוש בארעא

"And we shall be fruitful in the land": as the Targum renders it, "and we shall increase in the land."

Rashi on Bereishis 26:22

Yitzchak moves on and digs once more, and this time there is no quarrel. Radak explains: he went a little farther from their border, to a place where there was no doubt the land was not Gerar's. He called it Rechovos, "wide spaces," and said, "For now Hashem has made room for us, and we shall be fruitful in the land." Radak: because there is no adversary and no quarreller. Rashi cites the Targum: we shall increase in the land.

Notice who gets the credit. Yitzchak dug the well, but he does not say, "I have made room." He says, "Hashem has made room for us." Topic 38 asks "whether any reopening can be named as space that Hashem has made." That is the right question. If the Strait reopens, if a government is formed, if crews come home, the work of many people will have gone into it. The naming that Yitzchak teaches is still: Hashem has made room.

Three wells, three Temples

יספר הכתוב ויאריך בענין הבארות, ואין בפשוטי הספור תועלת ולא כבוד גדול ליצחק, והוא ואביו עשו אותם בשוה. אבל יש בדבר ענין נסתר בתוכו, כי בא להודיע דבר עתיד

Scripture tells at length the matter of the wells, and in the plain sense of the story there is no benefit, nor great honour to Yitzchak, for he and his father did them alike. But there is a hidden matter within it, for it comes to make known a future thing.

Ramban on Bereishis 26:20

Ramban asks why the Torah tells the story of the wells at such length, when the plain story brings Yitzchak no special honour. His answer is that the wells hint at the future.

וקרא הראשון עשק, ירמז לבית הראשון אשר התעשקו עמנו ועשו אותנו כמה מחלוקות וכמה מלחמות עד שהחריבוהו. והשני קרא שמה שטנה, שם קשה מן הראשון, והוא הבית השני שקרא אותו כשמו שכתוב בו (עזרא ד ו) "ובמלכות אחשורוש בתחלת מלכותו כתבו שטנה על ישבי יהודה וירושלם", וכל ימיו היו לנו לשטנה עד שהחריבוהו וגלו ממנו גלות רעה

He called the first Esek: it alludes to the First House, over which they contended with us and made against us many disputes and many wars until they destroyed it. The second he called Sitnah, a harsher name than the first: it is the Second House, which is called by this name, as it is written of it, "And in the reign of Achashverosh, at the beginning of his reign, they wrote a sitnah [accusation] against the inhabitants of Yehudah and Jerusalem" (Ezra 4:6); and all its days they were a sitnah to us until they destroyed it and we went from it into a bitter exile.

Ramban on Bereishis 26:20

והשלישי קרא רחובות, הוא הבית העתיד שיבנה במהרה בימינו, והוא יעשה בלא ריב ומצה

And the third he called Rechovos: this is the future House, which will be built speedily in our days, and it will be made without quarrel and strife.

Ramban on Bereishis 26:20

Esek is the First Temple, over which the nations contended with us until they destroyed it. Sitnah, a harsher name, is the Second Temple; the same word appears in Ezra (4:6), when enemies wrote a *sitnah*, an accusation, against Yehudah and Jerusalem. Rechovos is the Third Temple, "which will be built speedily in our days, and it will be made without quarrel and strife."

Topic 23 asks about "analogous risks of self-undermining conflict in present arrangements," and the sheet adds a caution: "invitation to examine, not automatic application." Ramban's reading is about the Temples, not about shipping lanes or coalitions. Its lesson for us is about the shape of history: contention and accusation are not the end. The third well, the wide space, is promised, and it will come without strife.

THE TEXT IN FULL

Bereishis 26:17–22

Hebrew as in the Sefaria source text, vowels removed, with substitute forms for the Divine Name. English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, with the divine names written G-d and L-rd.

17 וילך משם יצחק ויחן בנחל־גרר וישב שם

So Isaac departed from there and encamped in the wadi of Gerar, where he settled.

18 וישב יצחק ויחפר את־בארת המים אשר חפרו בימי אברהם אביו ויסתמום פלשתים אחרי מות אברהם ויקרא להן שמות כשמת אשר־קרא להן אביו

Isaac dug anew the wells which had been dug in the days of his father Abraham and which the Philistines had stopped up after Abraham's death; and he gave them the same names that his father had given them.

19 ויחפרו עבדי־יצחק בנחל וימצאו־שם באר מים חיים

But when Isaac's servants, digging in the wadi, found there a well of spring water,

20 ויריבו רעי גרר עם־רעי יצחק לאמר לנו המים ויקרא שם־הבאר עשק כי התעשקו עמו

the herdsmen of Gerar quarreled with Isaac's herdsmen, saying, "The water is ours." He named that well Esek, because they contended with him.

21 ויחפרו באר אחרת וריבו גם־עליה ויקרא שמה שטנה

And when they dug another well, they disputed over that one also; so he named it Sitnah.

22 ויעתק משם ויחפר באר אחרת ולא רבו עליה ויקרא שמה רחבות ויאמר כי־עתה הרחיב ה' לנו ופרינו בארץ

He moved from there and dug yet another well, and they did not quarrel over it; so he called it Rehoboth, saying, "Now at last the L-RD has granted us ample space to increase in the land."

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. Yitzchak restored his father's names to the wells. What "old names" in your own life are worth restoring?
2. Radak says the name Esek was a record of the challenge. Why is it important to name a dispute honestly, even after it ends?
3. Yitzchak said "Hashem has made room for us," not "I have made room." How do we give that credit when our own work contributed?

4. Ramban reads Rechovos as the Third Temple, built without strife. What would it take for us to live now in a way that looks toward it?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Bereishis 26:17–18: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.17-18
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.17.1
- Radak on Bereishis 26:18: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.18.2
- Bereishis 26:19–20: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.19-20
- Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:19: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Genesis.26.19.1
- Radak on Bereishis 26:19: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.19.2
- Ramban on Bereishis 26:17–19: https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.17.1
- Yirmiyahu 17:13 (closing clause): https://www.sefaria.org/Jeremiah.17.13
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:20: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.20.1
- Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:20: https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Genesis.26.20.1
- Sforno on Bereishis 26:20: https://www.sefaria.org/Sforno_on_Genesis.26.20.1
- Radak on Bereishis 26:20: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.20.2
- Bereishis 26:21: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.21
- Radak on Bereishis 26:21: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.21.1
- Bereishis 26:22: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.22
- Radak on Bereishis 26:22: https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.22.1
- Rashi on Bereishis 26:22: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.22.1
- Ramban on Bereishis 26:20: https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.20.1

CHAPTER 11

Words That Rise: Kuntres Acharon on Speech and Intention

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3: the daily portion for 30 Cheshvan 5787

Topics from the sheet: 13. Kuntres Acharon Essay 3 on speech and intention; 42. Kuntres Acharon on spoken word and intention applied to diplomacy

The day's portion

The daily Tanya portion for Tuesday 30 Cheshvan 5787, as posted on Chabad.org, is the middle of the third essay of Kuntres Acharon, the "Final Tract" printed at the end of Tanya. It begins with "However, the difference between Torah and prayer without intention is self-evident," and runs to the reference to Mikdash Melech. The short essay as a whole is about a hard question: what happens to words of Torah and prayer said without full intention?

The question

> להבין מה שכתוב בשער היחודים פרק ב', דעל־ידי תורה שלא בכוונה נבראים מלאכים בעולם היצירה
>
> *To understand what is written in Sha'ar HaYichudim, chapter 2, that through Torah [learned] without intention, angels are created in the world of Yetzirah.*
>
> Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (opening)

> דלית קלא דאתאביד כו' בר קלא דאורייתא וצלותא דסליק ובקע כו
>
> *"There is no voice that is lost … except the voice of Torah and prayer, which rises and pierces …"*
>
> Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3, citing Zohar, Shelach

The Alter Rebbe, Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi, starts from a statement in his own Sha'ar HaYichudim: through Torah learned without intention, angels are created in the world of Yetzirah. He cites the Zohar: no voice is lost, except that the voice of Torah and prayer rises and pierces the heavens.

והנה, מכוונת התפלה נבראו מלאכים בעולם הבריאה כמו מכוונת התורה, ובלא כוונה – נדחית למטה לגמרי

Now, from the intention of prayer angels are created in the world of Beriah, as from the intention of Torah; and without intention it is pushed down entirely.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (opening)

Then comes the difficulty. Prayer with intention creates angels in Beriah, a higher world, as Torah with intention does. But prayer without intention, the Zohar says, is pushed down entirely, into the lowest firmament, where it is called a "disqualified prayer." Why should Torah without intention still rise to Yetzirah, while prayer without intention falls?

The answer: understanding is built into study

אך ההפרש בין תורה לתפלה שלא בכוונה, מובן מאליו, כי לימוד התורה הוא מבין ויודע מה שלומד, דבלאו הכי לא מיקרי לימוד כלל

But the difference between Torah and prayer without intention is self-evident. For in the study of Torah one understands and knows what he is learning, since otherwise it is not called study at all.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3

The answer is in the nature of study itself. A person who learns Torah understands what he is learning. If he does not understand, it is not called learning at all. So even study without the higher intention still carries understanding with it.

רק, שלומד סתם, בלא כוונה לשמה מאהבת ה' שבלבו בבחינת גילוי, רק מאהבה המסותרת הטבעית, אך אינו לומד שלא לשמה ממש להתגדל כו'

Only, he is learning plainly, without the intention "for its own sake" out of a love of Hashem revealed in his heart, but only out of the hidden, natural love; yet he is not learning truly not-for-its-sake, to make himself great, and so on.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3

The Alter Rebbe is precise about the kind of person he means. This is not someone learning to make himself great. It is someone learning "plainly," out of the hidden, natural love every Jew has for Hashem, but without a love that is revealed in his heart. His study is not for its own sake in the full sense. But it is also not for a bad purpose.

דהא לא סליק לעילא מן שמשא, כמו שכתוב בפרשת ויחי דף רכ"ג עמוד ב', והיינו משום שמחשבתו וכוונתו הן מתלבשות באותיות הדבור ואינן מניחות אותן לסלקא לעילא

For this does not rise above the sun, as it is written in [the Zohar,] Parashas Vayechi, page 223b. And that is because his thought and intention are clothed in the letters of the speech and do not let them rise upward.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3

Here is the heart of the passage. Torah learned for self-aggrandisement "does not rise above the sun." Why? Because the person's thought and intention are clothed in the letters of his speech, and they hold the letters down. The words would rise on their own. His intention weighs them.

That is a striking image. Speech has a direction. Intention is not a separate thing laid on top of words; it is the garment they wear. A good intention lets words rise. A self-serving one keeps them "under the sun," the phrase Koheles uses for what is vain.

Prayer with foreign thoughts

והכי נמי בתפלה שלא בכוונה, שמחשב מחשבות זרות (אלא מפני שכוונתו לשמים, לכך יש לה תיקון בקל לחזור ולעלות, כשמתפלל בכוונה אפילו תפלה אחת מלוקטת מתפלות כל השנה, כמו שכתוב ב"מקדש מלך" פרשת פקודי)

And so too in prayer without intention, where he thinks foreign thoughts. (But because his intention is for Heaven, it therefore has an easy repair, to return and rise, when he prays with intention even one prayer gathered from the prayers of the whole year, as written in Mikdash Melech, Parashas Pekudei.)

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3

Prayer without intention, where a person's mind wanders to other things, is in the same category. But the Alter Rebbe adds a comforting parenthesis. Because the person's basic intention is for Heaven, the repair is easy. When he prays with intention even once, "even one prayer gathered from the prayers of the whole year," all those wandering prayers can rise with it.

This is one of the gentlest lines in Tanya. A whole year of distracted davening is not lost. One prayer said with the heart can gather it up.

Better than you thought

והנה, תפלה פסולה עדיפא מתורה שלא לשמה ממש, שהיא תחת השמש, והתפלה היא גו רקיע כו'. אבל תורה סתם, שאינה שלא לשמה רק מאהבה מסותרת טבעית, לא גרעא מהבל פיהן של תינוקת־של־בית־רבן, דסליק לעילא מפני שהוא הבל שאין בו חטא

Now, a disqualified prayer is better than Torah that is truly not for its own sake, which is under the sun, while the prayer is "within the firmament," and so on. But plain Torah, which is not not-for-its-sake but only out of a hidden, natural love, is no less than the breath of the mouths of schoolchildren, which rises upward because it is breath in which there is no sin.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3

שהמלאכים הם מעלים ההבל של תינוקת־של־בית־רבן עד אצילות

… that the angels raise up the breath of schoolchildren as far as Atzilus.

Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (close), citing Zohar 255b

The essay ends with a ranking. A disqualified prayer is still better than Torah learned for a bad purpose: the prayer is at least "within the firmament," while that Torah is under the sun. But plain Torah, learned without the higher intention but out of the hidden natural love, is no less than the breath of schoolchildren, which rises because it is "breath in which there is no sin." The Zohar says the angels carry that breath all the way up to Atzilus, the highest world.

So the Alter Rebbe's essay moves from difficulty to encouragement. Words said with the wrong intention are held down. Words said plainly, without a bad intention, rise further than the speaker might think.

Speech and intention in public life

The sheet sets this passage beside "public diplomatic language versus private accountability" (topics 13 and 42), and links it to the two-edged sword of Tehillim 149:6 (chapter 7).

The connection needs care. It would be easy to use the Kuntres Acharon as a weapon: to say that this leader's words are "under the sun" because his intentions are bad. That would be exactly the misuse the laws of speech forbid. The Alter Rebbe is writing about a person's own Torah and prayer, and the only intentions any of us can know are our own.

What the passage can do is give us a vocabulary. In November 2026 there is a great deal of public language. On 10 November, Reuters reported that Iran's top security official, Mohsen Rezaei, spoke of "imaginary talks," while Qatar's prime minister described his talks in Washington as positive and President Trump spoke of "positive momentum." In

Jerusalem, the new Knesset's members each said two words, *ani mitchayev*, "I pledge." Words like these have consequences, and every speaker is accountable for them. The passage teaches that what makes speech rise or fall is not only the words, but the intention clothed in them. That standard applies first to ourselves.

The sheet calls it "speech that is directed." An oath of office is a good example of speech that is meant to be directed: a person stands, in front of the nation, and binds himself. The Kuntres Acharon would add that its worth depends on the intention that wears it, and on whether the deeds that follow lift it up. We cannot see that intention in anyone else. We can pray that it is there.

The comfort for ordinary people

The most important line in the passage for most readers is the parenthesis about prayer. Many people who say Tehillim, or daven three times a day, worry that their words are empty because their minds wander. The Alter Rebbe answers: because your basic intention is for Heaven, the repair is easy. One prayer with intention gathers the rest.

On a day like 30 Cheshvan 5787, with the whole Tehillim said in many shuls, the cycle ending with Psalm 150, and the new month beginning, that is good news. It is not too late for any of those words to rise.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. The Alter Rebbe says intention is "clothed" in the letters of speech. How does that image change the way you think about your own words?
2. Why might Torah learned plainly, without a bad purpose, rise higher than prayer said without attention?
3. The repair for a year of distracted prayer is one prayer said with intention. What helps you pray that way?
4. How can we hold leaders accountable for their public words without claiming to know their intentions?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (opening): https://www.sefaria.org/Tanya,_Part_V;_Kuntres_Acharon.3.1
- Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3, citing Zohar, Shelach: https://www.sefaria.org/Tanya,_Part_V;_Kuntres_Acharon.3.1
- Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3: https://www.sefaria.org/Tanya,_Part_V;_Kuntres_Acharon.3.2
- Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (close), citing Zohar 255b: https://www.sefaria.org/Tanya,_Part_V;_Kuntres_Acharon.3.7

CHAPTER 12

Under the Rod: Bechoros 53 and Honest Counting

The Daf Yomi for 30 Cheshvan 5787, with Vayikra 27:32–33

Topics from the sheet: 14. Bechorot 53 on valuation and firstborn obligations; 43. Bechorot 53 valuation and absence of formed government

What the daf is about

The Daf Yomi for 30 Cheshvan 5787 is Bechoros 53. The sheet describes it as a page "on valuation and firstborn obligations." That is close, but not exact. Bechoros 53 opens the ninth chapter of the tractate, and its subject is *ma'aser beheimah*, the tithe of animals. Firstborn animals and valuations come up along the way, as comparisons. This chapter follows the page as it actually reads.

Under the rod

> וְכֹל־מַעְשַׂר בָּקָר וָצֹאן כֹּל אֲשֶׁר־יַעֲבֹר תַּחַת הַשָּׁבֶט הָעֲשִׂירִי יִהְיֶה־קֹדֶשׁ לַה׳

And every tithe of the herd and the flock, all that passes under the rod, the tenth shall be holy to Hashem.

Vayikra 27:32

> לֹא יְבַקֵּר בֵּין־טוֹב לְרָע וְלֹא יְמִירֶנּוּ

He shall not inquire whether it is good or bad, and he shall not exchange it.

Vayikra 27:33 (opening)

The Torah's law is set out at the end of Vayikra. Every tenth animal of the herd and flock, "all that passes under the rod," is holy. The owner lets the animals pass one by one through a narrow opening, counts them, and marks the tenth with a rod. He may not choose which animal will be tenth. "He shall not inquire whether it is good or bad."

The Mishnah

מעשר בהמה נוהג בארץ ובחוצה לארץ, בפני הבית ושלא בפני הבית, בחולין אבל לא במוקדשין. ונוהג בבקר ובצאן, ואינן מתעשרים מזה על זה. בכבשים ובעזים ומתעשרין מזה על זה

The tithe of animals applies in the Land and outside the Land, in the presence of the Temple and not in the presence of the Temple, to unconsecrated animals but not to consecrated ones. It applies to cattle and to the flock, but they are not tithed one for the other; to sheep and to goats, and they are tithed one for the other.

Bechoros 53a (Mishnah)

The Mishnah lists where the tithe applies: in the Land and outside it, when the Temple stands and when it does not, to ordinary animals but not to consecrated ones. It applies to cattle and to sheep and goats; but cattle and flock are not tithed one for the other, while sheep and goats are. The Mishnah goes on to add that animals of a new year and of an old year are not tithed one for the other.

Why it is not practised today

If the tithe applies "when the Temple does not stand," why does no one separate it now? The Gemara gives two answers.

אמר רב הונא: גזירה משום יתום

Rav Huna said: [it is] a decree on account of an orphan [animal].

Bechoros 53a

Rav Huna: it is a rabbinic decree, because of an orphaned animal, whose mother died before it was born, which is exempt from the tithe and might be counted in by mistake. The Gemara objects: if so, the same concern existed in Temple times, and it could be met then by a public announcement. It could be met the same way now.

אלא אמר רבה: משום תקלה

Rather, Rabbah said: on account of a mishap.

Bechoros 53a

אין מקדישין, ואין מעריכין, ואין מחרימין בזמן הזה

One may not consecrate, nor make valuations, nor devote [property] in the present time.

Bechoros 53a (baraisa)

So Rabbah gives a different reason: *takalah*, a mishap. An animal consecrated today, with no Temple to bring it to, is a standing risk that someone will use holy property by mistake. The proof is a baraisa: today, one may not consecrate, nor make valuations,

nor devote property. This is where the word “valuations” in the sheet comes from. It is cited as a parallel: all forms of consecration are held back in our time, for the same reason.

Count honestly

The Gemara then asks: could an owner not simply blemish the animal that will be tenth, so that it never becomes holy in a way that creates a risk? No.

> לא יבקר בין טוב לרע” אמר רחמנא

“He shall not inquire whether it is good or bad” (Vayikra 27:33), said the Merciful One.

Bechoros 53b

“He shall not inquire whether it is good or bad.” The owner may not arrange the count in advance. He cannot know which animal will come tenth, and he may not plant a chosen one in that place. The count has to be honest.

And could he blemish the whole flock?

> מהרה יבנה בית המקדש, ובעינן בהמה להקרבה וליכא

… speedily the Temple will be built, and we will need animals for offering, and there will be none.

Bechoros 53b

The Gemara’s answer is one of the most moving lines in Seder Kodashim. Speedily the Temple will be built, and we will need unblemished animals for offerings, and there will be none. The law of a suspended mitzvah is shaped by the expectation that it will return.

Year by year

> שנה שנה” — לשנה הקשתיו, ולא לדבר אחר

“Year by year” (Devarim 14:22): I have juxtaposed them with regard to the year, and not with regard to another matter.

Bechoros 53b (Rava)

Later on the page, the Gemara explains why animals of a new year and of an old year are not tithed together, although sheep and goats are. Rava: the verse says “year by year” (Devarim 14:22). The animal tithe is compared to the grain tithe with regard to the year, and not with regard to anything else. Each year’s flock is counted on its own.

Yitzchak’s tithe

There is a link here to the Chumash of the day. Rashi on Bereishis 26:12 said that the hundredfold of Yitzchak’s harvest was measured against an estimate “for tithes” (chapter 9). Yitzchak counted his blessing in order to give a tenth of it. Bechoros 53 is

about the same act in the flock: counting honestly, without picking, so that the tenth may be holy.

Counting and responsibility

Topics 14 and 43 set the daf beside "how electoral majorities, or their absence, assign responsibility" and "how the absence of a formed government assigns or delays responsibility." The sheet's gloss is "demand for accurate valuation."

The page supports that gloss in its own way. It is a page about honest counting. The owner may not "inquire whether it is good or bad." He may not arrange the order to get the result he wants. Each year is counted by itself; old and new are not mixed.

The 26th Knesset was elected on that kind of count. According to the Central Elections Committee's official final results, published on 4 November 2026, 5,717,397 people voted out of 7,331,981 eligible, a turnout of 77.98 per cent. (The figure of 77.9 per cent on the sheet matches the earlier published count of 30 October, not the final one. This booklet uses the final figure.) The seats were: Likud 27; Yashar! 21; Together 12; the Joint List 11; the Democrats 8; Ra'am 8; Yisrael Beytenu 7; Otzma Yehudit 7; United Torah Judaism 7; Shas 6; and Religious Zionism–Zehut 6.

When the President consulted the factions, the Times of Israel reported, members representing 67 seats recommended Gadi Eisenkot, 46 recommended Benjamin Netanyahu, and United Torah Judaism, with 7, recommended no one. On the evening of Saturday 7 November the President announced that he would give the mandate to Eisenkot, and the ceremony took place on Sunday 8 November. He has 28 days, which the President may extend by up to 14 more.

The count is the count. Like the flock passing under the rod, it was not arranged in advance, and it now places responsibility where it falls. A government has not yet been formed, and the task of forming one has been given to one member. Responsibility is not suspended in the meantime; it is held. Rabbah's word, *takalah*, is a reminder that a holding period has its own risks, and that the Sages handled such periods with care, not with neglect. Rava's "year by year" is a reminder that each count stands on its own.

A suspended mitzvah that waits

The most striking idea on the page is the reason for not blemishing the whole flock. The tithe is not practised today, but the law is shaped as if the Temple might be rebuilt tomorrow. Nothing is done that would make the mitzvah impossible when it returns.

That is a model for living in an interim. Whether the interim is national, while a government is formed, or personal, it asks us not to close off what we are waiting for.

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. “He shall not inquire whether it is good or bad.” Why does the Torah insist that the tenth animal be chosen by count and not by preference?
2. Rabbah says the tithe is held back today because of the risk of a mishap. When is holding back the more responsible choice?
3. The Gemara does not blemish the whole flock, because the Temple may be rebuilt speedily. What in your own life do you keep ready for a future you are waiting for?
4. What does it mean that responsibility is “held,” not suspended, while a government is being formed?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Vayikra 27:32: https://www.sefaria.org/Leviticus.27.32
- Vayikra 27:33 (opening): https://www.sefaria.org/Leviticus.27.33
- Bechoros 53a (Mishnah): https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53a.1
- Bechoros 53a: https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53a.7
- Bechoros 53a (baraisa): https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53a.9
- Bechoros 53b: https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53b.2
- Bechoros 53b (Rava): https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53b.16

CHAPTER 13

Blessing the New Month: Rosh Chodesh Kislev and Unfinished Things

Shemos 12:2 with Rashi, Berachos 16b, and the Hayom Yom

Topics from the sheet: 15. Transition into Kislev and blessing the new month; 44. Blessing of Kislev and unfinished processes

Two days of Rosh Chodesh

Cheshvan 5787 has thirty days, so Rosh Chodesh Kislev is kept for two days: Tuesday 10 November 2026, which is the thirtieth of Cheshvan, and Wednesday 11 November, the first of Kislev. The new month was blessed in shul on the Shabbos before, Shabbos Chayei Sarah, 7 November.

The Hayom Yom entry read on 30 Cheshvan begins with that same blessing.

> מברכים ר"ח כסלו. אמירת כל התהילים בהשכמה. יום התוועדות.
>
> *Bless Rosh Chodesh Kislev. Say the entire Tehillim in the early morning. Day of farbrengen.*
>
> Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704)

Bless Rosh Chodesh Kislev. Say the whole Tehillim early in the morning. A day of farbrengen. It is a short line, and it holds a whole approach to time: a new month is greeted with blessing, with praise and with gathering together.

The first commandment

> החדש הזה לכם ראש חדשים ראשון הוא לכם לחדשי השנה
>
> *This month shall be for you the head of months; it shall be the first for you of the months of the year.*
>
> Shemos 12:2

> הראהו לבנה בחדושה ואמר לו כשהירח מתחדש יהיה לך ראש חדש
>
> *He showed him the moon in its renewal and said to him: when the moon renews itself, it shall be for you the head of a month (Mechilta).*
>
> Rashi on Shemos 12:2

The first mitzvah given to Israel as a people is the sanctification of the new moon. Rashi, following the Mechilta, says that Hashem showed Moshe the moon in its renewal and

said: when the moon renews itself, that is the head of the month. The Jewish calendar begins with looking up at a thin crescent and declaring that something new has started.

The moon is the most fitting sign for that. It never stays the same. It grows and wanes and disappears and returns. A month that begins in darkness can still be blessed, because the light is coming back.

The prayer of the new month

On the Shabbos before Rosh Chodesh, the congregation says a prayer that begins with the words of Rav, recorded in the Gemara.

> רב בתר צלותיה אמר הכי: "יהי רצון מלפניך ה' אלקינו שתתן לנו חיים ארוכים, חיים של שלום, חיים של טובה, חיים של ברכה, חיים של פרנסה, חיים של חלוץ עצמות, חיים שיש בהם יראת חטא, חיים שאין בהם בושה וכלימה, חיים של עושר וכבוד, חיים שתהא בנו אהבת תורה ויראת שמים, חיים שתמלא לנו את כל משאלות לבנו לטובה
>
> *Rav, after his prayer, said this: "May it be Your will, Hashem our G-d, that You give us long life, a life of peace, a life of goodness, a life of blessing, a life of livelihood, a life of bodily vigour, a life in which there is fear of sin, a life in which there is no shame or disgrace, a life of wealth and honour, a life in which we have love of Torah and fear of Heaven, a life in which You fulfil all the requests of our heart for good."*
>
> Berachos 16b (the source of the Shabbos Mevarchim prayer "Yehi ratzon")

Rav said this prayer every day after his Amidah. The prayer said on Shabbos Mevarchim opens with his words. It is a list of requests for an ordinary life: long life, peace, goodness, livelihood, health, fear of sin, no shame, love of Torah. None of it is dramatic. All of it is needed.

A blessing looks forward

The sheet's gloss on topic 15 is four words: "blessing looks forward." Its topic 44 adds that "political and diplomatic processes remain open."

That is a fair description of the morning of 30 Cheshvan 5787. Several processes were begun and none was finished.

- The 26th Knesset was sworn in on the afternoon of 10 November. Its first task is to form a government, and that has not happened yet.
- President Herzog gave the mandate to Gadi Eisenkot on Sunday 8 November, after members representing 67 seats recommended him. The law gives him 28 days, which the President may extend by up to 14 more. As of the swearing-in, no government had been presented.

- In the Gulf, talks about ending the war and reopening the Strait of Hormuz were reported from several sides, with very different descriptions. Reuters reported on 10 November that President Trump said a new offensive was unlikely because of "positive momentum," that Qatar's prime minister called his talks in Washington positive, and that Iran's top security official spoke of "imaginary talks."
- At sea, the weekly UKMTO report for the week ending 6 November counted 325 transits of the Strait from 29 October to 4 November, about 65 per cent below the level before the conflict. Crews remain stranded, and the sources give different figures for the seafarers who have died.

None of these processes reached its end on 10 November. The blessing of the month does not pretend that they did. It looks forward.

Kislev

Kislev is a month of light that arrives in the dark. Its days are among the shortest of the year, and it carries Chanukah, which this year begins on the evening of Friday 4 December, the eve of 25 Kislev. In Chabad, it also carries the nineteenth of Kislev, which this year falls on Sunday 29 November and marks the Alter Rebbe's release from prison in 5559 (1798), the author of the Tanya studied in chapter 11.

So the month that opens on the day of the swearing-in is a month that, by its own calendar, promises an increase of light. That says nothing about any government or any strait. It is simply the shape of the month.

Blessing without forecasting

There is a temptation, on a day full of beginnings, to turn a blessing into a prediction. To say that because the month is Kislev, a government will be formed in light; or that because Chanukah is coming, the Strait will reopen. The blessing of the month does not do that. It asks for life, peace and livelihood, and it leaves the timing to Hashem.

That is the posture this booklet has tried to keep throughout. The numbers have been recorded from official and dated sources. Where a figure could not be confirmed, that has been said. The motives of governments and leaders have not been guessed at. And over all of it, the Tehillim of the day have said what the numbers cannot: "Your kingship is a kingship of all worlds, and Your dominion is in every generation."

FOR THE TABLE

Questions

1. The first mitzvah given to Israel was to see the moon and declare a new month. Why might the Torah begin with time?

2. Rav's prayer asks for an ordinary life: livelihood, health, love of Torah. Which of its requests is most on your heart this month?
3. How do we bless a process that is not finished without pretending to know how it will end?
4. Kislev brings light in the darkest days of the year. Where would you most like to see light this month?

Sources quoted in this chapter

- Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704): https://www.chabad.org/dailystudy/hayomyom.asp?tdate=11/10/2026
- Shemos 12:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Exodus.12.2
- Rashi on Shemos 12:2: https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Exodus.12.2.1
- Berachos 16b (the source of the Shabbos Mevarchim prayer "Yehi ratzon"): https://www.sefaria.org/Berakhot.16b.22

Appendix

Appendix: the fifty topics and their chapters

Each topic on the sheet for 30 Cheshvan 5787, by number, with the chapter where it is treated.

1. Alphabetic structure of Psalm 145 vs incomplete Knesset arithmetic → Chapter 1

2. Psalm 145:14 upholding the fallen applied to blocked wells and Hormuz → Chapter 2

3. Warning of Psalm 146:3–4 against trust in princes → Chapter 3

4. Psalm 146:7–9 as covenantal measure for Hormuz reopening conditions → Chapter 4

5. Psalm 147:2–3 gathering the dispersed and household stability → Chapter 5

6. Numbering of the stars in Psalm 147:4 vs limited human plans → Chapter 5

7. Psalm 148 cosmic summons and regional mediators → Chapter 6

8. Psalm 149:2 local resilience in the hills of Jerusalem → Chapter 7

9. Final Hallel of Psalm 150 and Hayom Yom merit of communal Tehillim → Chapter 8

10. Wells of Genesis 26:13–22 (Esek, Sitnah, Rechovot) as pattern → Chapter 10

11. Rashi on Philistines stopping wells for security reasons → Chapter 9

12. Isaac re-digging Abraham's wells and naming Rechovot → Chapter 10

13. Kuntres Acharon Essay 3 on speech and intention → Chapter 11

14. Bechorot 53 on valuation and firstborn obligations → Chapter 12

15. Transition into Kislev and blessing the new month → Chapter 13

16. Psalm 145:13 temporary character of any single administration → Chapter 1

17. Philistine envy of Isaac's growth and preference for status quo → Chapter 9

18. Living water in the valley and practical provision → Chapter 10

19. Move from Sitnah to Rechovot and risk of prolonged contention → Chapter 10

20. Psalm 146:5 help is the G-d of Jacob → Chapter 3

21. Cosmic praise of Psalms 148–150 and residual local arenas → Chapter 6

22. Tehillim cycle for the 30th and merit of communal recitation → Chapter 8

23. Ramban's reading of wells as allusions to Temples → Chapter 10

24. CEC presentation and mandate process as human plans that perish → Chapter 3

25. Concluding doxology of the Psalter as horizon → Chapter 8

26. Psalm 145:15–16 eyes of all look to You; ordinary household provision → Chapter 2

27. Alphabetic completeness vs incomplete mandate period → Chapter 1

28. Psalm 146:6 sea under the One who keeps faith forever → Chapter 4

29. Release of the bound in Psalm 146:7 and status of vessels → Chapter 4

30. Psalm 147:10–11 not in strength of the horse but those who fear Him → Chapter 5

31. Building of Jerusalem in Psalm 147:2 and ordinary communal life → Chapter 5

32. Psalm 148:11–12 kings and peoples and the swearing-in ceremony → Chapter 6

33. Psalm 149:4 Hashem takes pleasure in His people; posture of ordinary households → Chapter 7

34. Two-edged sword of Psalm 149:6 and speech/intention → Chapter 7

35. Psalm 150:6 let every soul praise and Hayom Yom minyan → Chapter 8

36. First well Esek and preference for restricted status → Chapter 10

37. Second well Sitnah and risk of hardening into dominion → Chapter 10

38. Third well Rechovot and naming as space Hashem has made → Chapter 10

39. Rashi's security reason and contemporary transit permits → Chapter 9

40. Isaac's growth and envy set beside economic disruption preference → Chapter 9

41. Living water and continuity of desalination and household stores → Chapter 10

42. Kuntres Acharon on spoken word and intention applied to diplomacy → Chapter 11

43. Bechorot 53 valuation and absence of formed government → Chapter 12

44. Blessing of Kislev and unfinished processes → Chapter 13

45. Psalm 145:17 Hashem is righteous in all His ways → Chapter 2

46. Upholding those who fall and condition of crews and vessels → Chapter 2

47. Psalm 146:10 Hashem will reign forever → Chapter 4

48. Cosmic praise of Psalm 148 and residual arenas of ordinary life → Chapter 6

49. Explicit cycle of Tehillim 145–150 and Hayom Yom communal merit → Chapter 8

50. Concluding doxology as horizon after arithmetic and status are noted → Chapter 8

Bibliography

Bibliography

Every source quoted or relied on, in the edition that was opened. All web pages were opened on 10 November 2026 unless stated. English renderings of Hebrew and Aramaic passages in the chapters are working translations prepared for this booklet; the published translations named here were consulted.

Primary texts

Tehillim (Psalms) 145–150. Hebrew: *Miqra according to the Masorah* (Sefaria edition). English for the full texts: *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.145 Passages quoted: Tehillim 145:1; Tehillim 145:2; Tehillim 145:3; Tehillim 145:4; Tehillim 145:8; Tehillim 145:9; Tehillim 145:11–12; Tehillim 145:13; Tehillim 145:14; Tehillim 145:15–16; Tehillim 145:17; Tehillim 145:18; Tehillim 145:21; Tehillim 146:1–2; Tehillim 146:3–4; Tehillim 146:5; Tehillim 146:6; Tehillim 146:7; Tehillim 146:8–9; Tehillim 146:10; Tehillim 147:2–3; Tehillim 147:4–5; Tehillim 147:8–9; Tehillim 147:10–11; Tehillim 147:12–14; Tehillim 148:1–2; Tehillim 148:5–6; Tehillim 148:7–8; Tehillim 148:11–13; Tehillim 148:14; Tehillim 149:1–2; Tehillim 149:4; Tehillim 149:5–6; Tehillim 149:9; Tehillim 150:2; Tehillim 150:3–5; Tehillim 150:6. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Other verses of Tanach: Amos 5:2; Yirmiyahu 17:13; Vayikra 27:32–33; Shemos 12:2. Hebrew: *Miqra according to the Masorah* (Sefaria edition). https://www.sefaria.org/Amos.5.2 · https://www.sefaria.org/Jeremiah.17.13 · https://www.sefaria.org/Leviticus.27.32 · https://www.sefaria.org/Exodus.12.2 Passages quoted: Amos 5:2; Shemos 12:2; Bereishis 26:12; Bereishis 26:13–14; Bereishis 26:15; Bereishis 26:16; Bereishis 26:17–18; Bereishis 26:19–20; Bereishis 26:21; Bereishis 26:22; Yirmiyahu 17:13 (closing clause); Vayikra 27:32; Vayikra 27:33 (opening). Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rashi (Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki, 1040–1105), Commentary on Tehillim 145–150. Hebrew: Sefaria Vocalized Edition. English reference translation: *The Judaica Press Complete Tanach with Rashi*, trans. A. J. Rosenberg. https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Psalms.145 Passages quoted: Rashi on Tehillim 145:14; Rashi on Tehillim 145:16; Rashi on Tehillim 145:21; Rashi on Tehillim 146:5; Rashi on Tehillim 146:6; Rashi on Tehillim 146:10; Rashi on Tehillim 147:10; Rashi on Tehillim 147:17; Rashi on Tehillim 148:6; Rashi on Tehillim 148:8; Rashi on Tehillim 149:6; Rashi on Tehillim 149:9. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Radak (Rabbi David Kimchi, c. 1160–1235), Commentary on Tehillim 145–150. Hebrew: *Derekh Mesilah* (Fürth, 1843), via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Psalms.145 Passages quoted: Radak on Tehillim 145:1; Radak on Tehillim 145:4; Radak on Tehillim 145:9; Radak on Tehillim 145:13; Radak on Tehillim 145:14; Radak on Tehillim 145:15; Radak on Tehillim 145:18; Radak on Tehillim 146:3 (one clause omitted); Radak on Tehillim 146:4 (one clause omitted in English); Radak on Tehillim 146:6; Radak on Tehillim 146:7; Radak on Tehillim 147:5; Radak on Tehillim 147:6; Radak on Tehillim 147:10; Radak on Tehillim 147:13; Radak on Tehillim 147:3; Radak on Tehillim 148:1; Radak on Tehillim 148:8; Radak on Tehillim 148:11; Radak on Tehillim 148:12; Radak on Tehillim 148:13; Radak on Tehillim 149:1; Radak on Tehillim 149:6; Radak on

Tehillim 149:4; Radak on Tehillim 150:1; Radak on Tehillim 150:6. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rabbi Avraham Ibn Ezra (1089–c. 1164), Commentary on Tehillim 145–150. Hebrew: Daat edition, via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Psalms.145 Passages quoted: Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:13; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:14; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:15; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:17; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 145:18; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:3; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:5; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 146:8; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:1; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:3; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:4; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 147:10; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 148:13; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 149:5; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:6; Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 150:2. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Metzudas David (Rabbi David Altschuler and Rabbi Yechiel Hillel Altschuler, 18th century), Commentary on Tehillim 145–150. Hebrew: "On Your Way" edition, via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Metzudat_David_on_Psalms.145 Passages quoted: Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:1; Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:14; Metzudas David on Tehillim 145:18; Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:4; Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:7; Metzudas David on Tehillim 146:8; Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:2; Metzudas David on Tehillim 147:10–11; Metzudas David on Tehillim 148:6; Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:5; Metzudas David on Tehillim 149:6; Metzudas David on Tehillim 150:6. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rashi, Commentary on the Torah: Bereishis 26:12–22 and Shemos 12:2. Hebrew and reference English: *Pentateuch with Rashi's Commentary*, ed. M. Rosenbaum and A. M. Silbermann (London, 1929–1934), via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.12 · https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Exodus.12.2 Passages quoted: Rashi on Shemos 12:2; Rashi on Bereishis 26:12 (citing Bereishis Rabbah); Rashi on Bereishis 26:12; Rashi on Bereishis 26:13 (citing Bereishis Rabbah); Rashi on Bereishis 26:15; Rashi on Bereishis 26:17; Rashi on Bereishis 26:20; Rashi on Bereishis 26:22. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Ramban (Rabbi Moshe ben Nachman, 1194–1270), Commentary on the Torah: Bereishis 26:14–20. Hebrew: Sefaria Vocalized Edition. Reference English: *Commentary on the Torah*, trans. Charles B. Chavel (New York: Shilo, 1971–1976). https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.14 Passages quoted: Ramban on Bereishis 26:14; Ramban on Bereishis 26:17; Ramban on Bereishis 26:17–19; Ramban on Bereishis 26:20. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Radak, Commentary on Bereishis 26:15–22. Hebrew: Sefaria Vocalized Edition. Reference English: Eliyahu Munk, *HaChut HaMeshulash*. https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.15 Passages quoted: Radak on Bereishis 26:15; Radak on Bereishis 26:18; Radak on Bereishis 26:19; Radak on Bereishis 26:20; Radak on Bereishis 26:21; Radak on Bereishis 26:22. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rabbi Avraham Ibn Ezra, Commentary on Bereishis 26:19–20. Hebrew: Piotrków edition, 1907–1911, via Sefaria. Reference English: H. Norman Strickman and Arthur M. Silver (Menorah, 1988–2004). https://www.sefaria.org/Ibn_Ezra_on_Genesis.26.19 Passages quoted: Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:19; Ibn Ezra on Bereishis 26:20. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Sforno (Rabbi Ovadiah Sforno, c. 1475–1550), Commentary on Bereishis 26:14–20. Hebrew: Sefaria Vocalized Edition. Reference English: Metsudah Publications, 2009. https://www.sefaria.org/

Sforno_on_Genesis.26.14 Passages quoted: Sforno on Bereishis 26:14; Sforno on Bereishis 26:15; Sforno on Bereishis 26:16; Sforno on Bereishis 26:20. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Talmud Bavli: Berachos 4b and 16b; Shabbos 118b; Bechoros 53a–53b. Hebrew and Aramaic: William Davidson Edition (Koren Noé Talmud, with the Steinsaltz commentary in English), via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Berakhot.4b · https://www.sefaria.org/Berakhot.16b · https://www.sefaria.org/Shabbat.118b · https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.53a Passages quoted: Berachos 4b; Berachos 16b (the source of the Shabbos Mevarchim prayer "Yehi ratzon"); Shabbos 118b; Bechoros 53a (Mishnah); Bechoros 53a; Bechoros 53a (baraisa); Bechoros 53b; Bechoros 53b (Rava). Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi (1745–1812), *Tanya*, Part V: Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3. Hebrew: Kehot Publication Society, via Sefaria. https://www.sefaria.org/Tanya,_Part_V;_Kuntres_Acharon.3 Passages quoted: Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3; Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (opening); Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3, citing Zohar, Shelach; Tanya, Kuntres Acharon, Essay 3 (close), citing Zohar 255b. Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, compiler, *Hayom Yom* (5703/1943), from the talks and letters of Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn. Entry for Shabbos 29 Cheshvan (5704), as shown on Chabad.org for Tuesday 30 Cheshvan 5787. English: Kehot Publication Society. https://www.chabad.org/dailystudy/hayomyom.asp?tdate=11/10/2026 Passages quoted: Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704), as read on Chabad.org for 30 Cheshvan 5787; Hayom Yom, 29 Cheshvan (5704). Sefaria, opened 10 November 2026.

Chabad.org, Daily Study: Tanya for 30 Cheshvan 5787 (Kuntres Acharon, middle of Essay 3), from *Lessons in Tanya* (Kehot Publication Society). https://www.chabad.org/dailystudy/tanya.asp?tdate=11/10/2026. Opened 10 November 2026 to confirm the day's portion.

Sources looked for but not available: a commentary of Sforno on Tehillim is not on Sefaria, so none is quoted; Metzudas David is used for Tehillim in its place.

Calendar

Hebcal, Hebrew date converter and Jewish calendar: 10 November 2026 = 30 Cheshvan 5787; Rosh Chodesh Kislev 10–11 November 2026; 19 Kislev 5787 = 29 November 2026; 25 Kislev 5787 = 5 December 2026. https://www.hebcal.com/converter. Opened 10 November 2026.

Elections and the Knesset

Central Elections Committee for the 26th Knesset, *Official Final Results*, published 4 November 2026. https://votes26.bechirot.gov.il/. The site did not open on 10 November 2026; figures are taken from the record of the published final table kept with this booklet's working papers (turnout 77.98 per cent; 5,717,397 votes of 7,331,981 eligible).

Stav Levaton, "President Herzog taps Eisenkot to form coalition, but path remains fraught," *The Times of Israel*, 8 November 2026. https://www.timesofisrael.com/president-herzog-taps-eisenkot-to-form-coalition-but-path-remains-fraught/

"26th Knesset to be sworn in today, with 46 first-time lawmakers taking their seats," *The Times of Israel* live blog, 10 November 2026. https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/26th-knesset-to-be-sworn-in-today-with-46-first-time-lawmakers-taking-their-seats/

The Times of Israel live blog, 10 November 2026 (opening session of the 26th Knesset; "positive momentum" and "imaginary" talks). https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-november-10-2026/

Hezki Baruch, "Herzog to Knesset: The people long for unity," *Israel National News*, 10 November 2026, 15:42 (UTC+2). https://www.israelnationalnews.com/news/435962

Nachum Perry, "Israel's 26th Knesset prepares to be sworn in as Eisenkot's bloc asserts control," *The Jerusalem Post*, 10 November 2026. https://www.jpost.com/israel-election-2026/article-914409

Amir Ettinger and Moran Azulay, "Israel's 26th Knesset convenes as political deadlock persists," *Ynetnews*, 10 November 2026. https://www.ynetnews.com/article/hkhobslrge

"46 newcomers and record 33 women: Israel's 26th Knesset takes office," *Ynetnews*, 10 November 2026. https://www.ynetnews.com/article/h111bhbecgg

The Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz

United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO), weekly overview for the week ending 6 November 2026. https://www.ukmto.org/-/media/ukmto/products/20261106-ukmto_vra_overview_u.pdf

Jay Hilotin, "Hormuz shipping 'below normal, but not stalled': UKMTO," *Gulf News*, 10 November 2026. https://gulfnews.com/world/mena/hormuz-shipping-below-normal-but-not-stalled-ukmto-1.500741839

Straits.live, Strait of Hormuz live tracker, page viewed 10 November 2026 ("Day 254"). https://straits.live/

"Constant state of danger takes toll on shipping crews in Strait of Hormuz," *The National* (Abu Dhabi), 9 November 2026. https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/uae/2026/11/09/safety-elusive-for-crews-stuck-at-sea-in-strait-of-hormuz-as-death-toll-climbs/

"Who are the seafarers caught in the US-Israeli war on Iran?" *Al Jazeera*, 9 November 2026. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/11/9/who-are-the-seafarers-caught-in-the-us-israeli-war-on-iran

"Shipping crews caught in the crossfire of the Hormuz conflict," *DW* (Deutsche Welle), video report, November 2026. https://www.dw.com/en/shipping-crews-caught-in-the-crossfire-of-the-hormuz-conflict/video-79789673

Nordland Research Institute, "When war comes close: Seafarers in the Persian Gulf tell of fear, pressure and support from the shipping company." https://www.nordlandsforskning.no/en/nyheter/nr-krigen-kommer-tett-p-sjfolk-i-persiabukta-forteller-om-frykt-press-og-sttte-fra-rederiet-1

"Trump says Qatar, UAE, other Gulf allies prefer 'status quo', to keep up Hormuz blockade," *Khaleej Times*, with Reuters, 10 November 2026. https://www.khaleejtimes.com/world/gulf/trump-uae-qatar-saudi-arabia-iran-conflict-hormuz-blockade

"Iran says in 'intensive' negotiations with US to avert war via mediators," *Khaleej Times,* November 2026. https://www.khaleejtimes.com/world/mena/iran-says-intensive-negotiations-us-avert-war

"UAE does not want new round of conflict but is 'braced for worst', Dr Gargash says," *The National,* 1 November 2026. https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/gulf/2026/11/01/uae-does-not-want-new-round-of-conflict-but-is-braced-for-worst-says-dr-gargash/

"Middle East must prepare for 'long period of uncertainty', says Dr Gargash," *The National,* 9 November 2026. https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/mena/2026/11/09/deterrence-and-diplomacy-needed-to-counter-impact-of-iran-war-says-dr-gargash/

"Iran's top security official says US should stop manufacturing 'fake news about imaginary talks'," Reuters via *Devdiscourse,* 10 November 2026. https://www.devdiscourse.com/article/international/4004148-irans-top-security-official-says-us-should-stop-manufacturing-fake-news-about-imaginary-talks

"Trump sees 'positive momentum' on Iran after Qatar PM talks," *AFP,* 10 November 2026. https://www.afp.com/en/trump-sees-positive-momentum-iran-after-qatar-pm-talks

"Erdogan warns against renewed attacks on Iran, says he raised concerns with Trump," *Al Arabiya English,* 9 November 2026. https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2026/11/09/erdogan-warns-against-renewed-attacks-on-iran-says-he-raised-concerns-with-trump

Persian Gulf Strait Authority, "General terms for passage," as posted by Iran Watch. https://www.iranwatch.org/sites/default/files/iran-persian-gulf-strait-authority-passage_general_terms.pdf

"After MoU, Iran's transit rules for Strait of Hormuz: Fill out a form," *The Indian Express,* November 2026. https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/explained-global/strait-of-hormuz-transit-rules-iran-permit-system-10748292/

"Baghaei: Ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz must coordinate with the relevant Iranian authorities," *CGTN,* 9 November 2026. https://news.cgtn.com/news/2026-11-09/news-1RVMrLoBri0/p.html

"Why is Iran exempting India, China, Qatar, Iraq from Hormuz restrictions?" *Al Jazeera,* 6 November 2026. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/11/6/why-is-iran-exempting-india-china-qatar-iraq-from-hormuz-restrictions

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine